# The golden-ratio threshold for a lattice Lévy walk and ties in coin-turning walks

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**Abstract**

We study the golden-ratio threshold for a lattice Lévy walk, an alternating renewal walk on $\mathbb{Z}$ started in equilibrium, with independent run lengths of tail $k^{-\alpha}$, $1 < \alpha < 2$. We compare the probability of each end, $\pm N$, after $N$ steps with that of the center. Wang, Li and Hänggi (2016) observed, as a heuristic, that the ends and the center decay at the same rate when $\alpha$ is the golden ratio. We prove the lattice form of their observation, with its constant. The ends beat the center for large $N$ exactly when $\alpha$ is below the golden ratio, and at the golden ratio the center still wins by a constant factor. The proof rests on a local limit theorem at the center, which holds for every first run that is finite almost surely. For runs of infinite mean we prove a local form of Lamperti's law at the center. We also study an aging walk (the coin-turning walk), which switches at step $k$ with probability $c/k$. With a fixed first step, every interior position ties with the end exactly at $c = 1$, for every $N$. The same holds for an aging walk with $d$ states, whose vector of counts is exactly uniform at the tie.

**Keywords.** Lévy walk, alternating renewal process, local limit theorem, persistent random walk, coin-turning walk, Pólya urn.
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## 1 Introduction

We study walks on $\mathbb{Z}$ that move in runs of alternating direction with random lengths. Let $A_N$ be the number of right steps among the first $N$. If the run lengths are independent, $A_N$ is the occupation time of an alternating renewal process [4, 5]. If they are also heavy-tailed, the walk is a lattice analogue of a Lévy walk. Lévy walks are a standard model of superdiffusion [7], and they also describe anomalous heat transport in one-dimensional lattices [8, 12]. The profile of a Lévy walk has a central peak and two ballistic side peaks [10, 6, 7], and the part of the profile between them is described by an infinite density [25, 26].

On the lattice we compare the end bins $A_N = N$ and $A_N = 0$, which the walk reaches only if one run covers all $N$ steps, with the center $A_N = N/2$, which it reaches in many ways. In the picture of heat spreading, the end bins are the lattice form of the ballistic side peaks of the standard Lévy walk (the walk without velocity fluctuations, see Remark 2.6). The center bin is the top of the central peak, and the stationary start used below is the equilibrated initial ensemble [6]. We ask when the ballistic ends beat the center.

For runs with geometric lengths this question is Problem 131 of Kagey's Open Problem Collection [1], posed for a Galton board. The walk is then the persistent random walk [36, 37], which remembers only its last step, and the center catches up with the ends when the expected number of switches is about $\log N$ [2].

In this paper we ask what happens if the walk remembers more. We study two kinds of memory.

- A walk with heavy-tailed runs remembers how long it has gone in its current direction. Its path is a sequence of runs of alternating direction, and the run lengths $\xi$ are independent with $\mathbb{P}(\xi \geq k) = k^{-\alpha}$ for $k \geq 1$.
- An aging walk remembers how old it is. It switches at step $k \geq 2$ with probability $c/k$. This is the coin-turning walk of Engländer and Volkov [21, 29] with $p_k = c/k$. (In the literature on renewal processes and Lévy walks, aging means instead that the process depends on the time since it was prepared [4, Sections 8 and 9].) We also give the walk $d$ directions. Then at step $k \geq 2$ it turns to each of the other $d-1$ directions with probability $\theta/(k+d-2)$, which is $c/k$ with $c = \theta$ when $d = 2$.

### 1.1 Why the golden ratio

Here is the heuristic. Theorem 2.4 and Corollary 2.5 make it rigorous. For heavy-tailed runs take $1 < \alpha < 2$, so a run has a finite mean $\mu$ but an infinite variance. Start the walk in equilibrium, at a typical time of a long sequence of runs. Then the first run is already in progress, and long runs are more likely to be in progress. The chance that this run covers all $N$ steps is of order $N^{1-\alpha}$, and this is the order of the end. For the center, the runs to the right and the runs to the left form two independent renewal processes, each making about $N/(2\mu)$ runs, and the walk ends in the center when they meet at level $N/2$. Each process fluctuates on the scale $N^{1/\alpha}$ of a stable law, so they meet at the same level with probability of order $N^{-1/\alpha}$. Hence the ratio of end to center is of order $N^{1-\alpha}/N^{-1/\alpha} = N^{1-\alpha+1/\alpha}$. The exponent vanishes when $\alpha^2 - \alpha - 1 = 0$, that is, at the golden ratio $\alpha = \varphi = (1+\sqrt{5})/2$. Below $\varphi$ the ends win, and above $\varphi$ the center wins. If the first run is a fresh run instead, the end is of order $N^{-\alpha}$, a factor $N$ smaller, and the center wins for every $1 < \alpha < 2$.

### 1.2 Setting and notation

Every walk in this paper takes $N$ steps $X_1, \dots, X_N \in \{+1, -1\}$, where $+1$ means right. Let $A_N = \#\{i \leq N : X_i = +1\}$ be the number of right steps, and write $P_N(k) = \mathbb{P}(A_N = k)$ for the probability of bin $k$, that is, of $k$ right steps, for whichever walk we study. Unless we say otherwise the first step is fair, $\mathbb{P}(X_1 = +1) = \frac{1}{2}$, and the rules treat the two directions alike, so $P_N(k) = P_N(N-k)$. We write $\mathbb{P}_+$ and $\mathbb{E}_+$ for probability and expectation given $X_1 = +1$. For even $N$ we put $h = N/2$ and call $C_N = P_N(h)$ the center and $E_N = P_N(N) = P_N(0)$ the end. Whenever $C_N$ appears, $N$ is even. A crossing is a value of the parameter at which a bin ties with an end, and for the center this means $C_N = E_N$. For heavy-tailed runs we do not locate a crossing at fixed $N$. There we prove which of $C_N$ and $E_N$ is larger for all large $N$ at fixed $\alpha$, and the golden ratio is the threshold for this sign.

All logarithms are natural, $H_k = \sum_{j \leq k} 1/j$ is the $k$-th harmonic number, and $\gamma$ is Euler's constant. Limits, $O(\cdot)$ and $o(\cdot)$ refer to $N \to \infty$, over even $N$ when $C_N$ appears. The constants implied by $O(\cdot)$ are absolute unless we name what they depend on.

Heavy-tailed runs (Section 2) have the exponent $\alpha$, the mean run length $\mu = \mathbb{E}\xi = \zeta(\alpha)$ for $\alpha > 1$, and the length $D$ of the first run. A fresh start has $D$ distributed as $\xi$, and the stationary

start has $\mathbb{P}(D = \ell) = \mathbb{P}(\xi \geq \ell)/\mu$. We put $R_N = E_N/C_N$, so the ends win exactly when $R_N > 1$. The aging walk (Section 3) has the constant $c \in (0, 2)$, and its version with $d$ states has the constant $\theta$ and the count vector $(n_1, \dots, n_d)$, where $n_i$ is the number of steps in state $i$. Symbols that only one section uses are defined in that section.

### 1.3 Results

In both models the start matters. For heavy-tailed runs it decides whether the threshold is $\varphi$ or 1, and for the aging walk it decides whether the crossing is exactly $c = 1$. The main results are Theorem 2.4 and Corollary 2.5 for heavy-tailed runs and Proposition 3.3 and Theorem 3.4 for aging walks. Theorems 2.4, 2.7 and 2.8 are proved in Appendix A, and Proposition 3.7 in Appendix B. The other results are proved where they are stated.

**Heavy-tailed runs.** For $1 < \alpha < 2$ and every first run that is finite almost surely, $C_N$ is asymptotic to an explicit constant times $N^{-1/\alpha}$ (Theorem 2.4). With the stationary start $R_N \sim C(\alpha)N^{1-\alpha+1/\alpha}$ for an explicit constant $C(\alpha)$. Here $C(\varphi) = 0.7761\dots$ (and $C(\varphi) < 0.952$ by elementary bounds), so at $\alpha = \varphi$ the center still wins. With a fresh start $R_N \to 0$ (Corollary 2.5).

For $\alpha \geq 2$ the center is of order $N^{-1/2}$, with an extra factor $(\log N)^{-1/2}$ at $\alpha = 2$, and $R_N \to 0$ with either start (Theorem 2.7). For $0 < \alpha < 1$ the runs have infinite mean and only the fresh start makes sense. Then $NC_N \to \frac{2}{\pi} \tan \frac{\pi\alpha}{2}$ and $R_N \to \infty$ (Theorem 2.8). So with a fresh start the ends win for $\alpha < 1$ and the center wins for $\alpha > 1$. We do not prove what happens at $\alpha = 1$ (Remark 2.9).

**Aging.** With a fixed first step and $c = 1$ the number of right steps is exactly uniform on $\{1, \dots, N\}$. The ratio of each interior bin to the end increases strictly in $c$, so every interior bin ties with the end exactly at $c = 1$, for every $N \geq 2$ (Proposition 3.3). With $d$ states, a start in state 1 and $\theta = 1$, the count vector is exactly uniform over all compositions $(n_1, \dots, n_d)$ of $N$ with $n_1 \geq 1$, and every other such bin ties with the corner $(N, 0, \dots, 0)$ exactly at $\theta = 1$, for every $N \geq 2$ (Theorem 3.4). A small change of the aging rate gives a chain that redraws or repeats its state, and its counts have exactly the law of Pólya's urn for every weight (Proposition 3.1).

With a fair first step each interior bin is twice as likely as an end at $c = 1$, and its crossing is unique and below 1 (Proposition 3.6). For the center the crossing is $c_N = 1 - \log 2/(\log N + \gamma + 2 - 2\log 2) + O((\log N)^{-3})$ (Proposition 3.7).

**Methods.** For heavy-tailed runs the walk is made of two independent renewal processes, one for the runs of each sign (Proposition 2.2). At the center we need a local limit theorem for each of them, with a delay for the first run. We obtain it from Gnedenko's local limit theorem for the sums of the run lengths. Sums of few runs that lie far above their mean are controlled by local bounds in the big-jump domain. For $\alpha < 1$ these bounds need one more step, in which we cut the runs into two halves. Then a Mellin transform identifies the limit with Lamperti's density.

For the aging walk all the exact laws come from one chain that draws afresh or repeats its state. The ties come from writing each ratio of a bin to the end as a sum over paths of products of odds that increase in $c$. For the fair start we couple the walk with the chain that draws afresh or repeats, whose counts are a mixture of binomial laws, and summation by parts turns the coupling into a local limit theorem with a rate.

### 1.4 Prior work

For heavy-tailed runs, Godrèche and Luck [4] give the transform of the occupation time of an alternating renewal process started at a renewal. They give the decay of the end for both starts [4, Eqs. (1.6) and (8.7)], and from the transform they derive, by a formal Laplace analysis in continuous time, the stable law of the occupation time for $1 < \alpha < 2$ [4, Section 7(iii), Eqs. (7.12) to (7.15)]. Read at the center, that law gives the constant of Theorem 2.4.

In probability theory the walk is the one-dimensional directionally reinforced random walk of Mauldin, Monticino and von Weizsäcker [33], whose limit laws were found by Horváth and Shao [34]. Cénac, Le Ny, de Loynes and Offret study it as a persistent random walk whose runs have general lengths. They give criteria for recurrence [31] and prove functional scaling limits [32], namely a Brownian motion for $\alpha \geq 2$, a stable Lévy process for $1 < \alpha < 2$ [32, Theorem 3.2] and an arcsine Lamperti process for $\alpha < 1$ [32, Theorem 3.3 and Eq. (3.25)]. Theorems 2.4, 2.7 and 2.8 are local forms of the marginals of these limits at the center. The end $E_N$ is a persistence event, and it is not a local form of these limits. Magdziarz, Scheffler, Straka and Żebrowski [35] prove limit theorems for Lévy walks in continuous space and time.

The scalings of the central peak and of the side peaks were known before [9, 10, 6, 7], but we did not find the balance of the two stated there. The observation that equal decay of the two singles out the golden ratio is due, as far as we know, to Wang, Li and Hänggi [12, Section 6.2.1.3, Eq. (6.49)], who used it as a heuristic for the exponent of anomalous heat conduction. They also mention that Lee-Dadswell, Nickel and Gray [13] had found the same conduction exponent $(3 - \sqrt{5})/2$ by a hydrodynamic argument. The two decay rates of the end, $N^{1-\alpha}$ and $N^{-\alpha}$, are the scalings of the ballistic peaks of a Lévy walk with and without an equilibrated start [6, Table I].

What we add for heavy-tailed runs is a lattice local limit theorem at the center for every first run that is finite almost surely, so for both starts. With it the comparison of the end with the center becomes a theorem with the explicit constant $C(\alpha)$, and at $\alpha = \varphi$ the center wins strictly. For $\alpha < 1$ the limit law of $A_N/N$ is Lamperti's [5], and we prove its local form at the center. We found only the integral law in the literature.

For aging walks, Dietz and Sethuraman [20] proved the limit law of $A_N/N$, Engländer and Volkov [21] gave a second proof, and Engländer, Volkov and Wang [29] found the scaling limit of the walk. For $d$ states the limit is a Dirichlet law [20, Theorem 1.4], and Bouguet and Cloez [23, Propositions 4.1 and 4.5] find the joint limit of the fractions of time and the current state. The exact uniform law for two states is an exercise in [29, Section 3.1, footnote 1], which also announces a general connection with Pólya urns. The law of the counts of the chain of Proposition 3.1 also follows from a result of Dietz, Lippitt and Sethuraman [24, Theorem 2.18] (Section 3.1).

Chapter 7 of the March 18, 2024 author draft of Engländer and Volkov's monograph [28] gives the two-state joint law with the last state, including the uniform case and positive integer urn weights.[1] Section 3 gives the precise overlaps and the time shift, separating the count law from the joint law and from the path law.

Pradhan, Roy and Ray [38] study, with the methods of physics, a persistent walk whose probability of reversal decays like a power of the time. When the power is one it is close to our aging walk, and they find its second moment and the tail of its runs.

What we add in Section 3 is the joint law of the counts and the last state for $d \geq 3$ states or a weight $\theta$ that is not an integer, the strict ordering that turns the uniform laws into ties

[1] The dated author upload is at https://www.researchgate.net/publication/379333206_Coin-Turning_Random_Walks_and_Inhomogeneous_Markov_Chains. All draft locators below refer to this version. We have not checked the numbering of the published edition.

(Proposition 3.3(b) and Theorem 3.4(b)), and for the fair start the expansion of the crossing (Proposition 3.7) with the local limit theorem with a rate behind it (Proposition B.3).

## 2 Heavy-tailed runs

In this section the walk remembers the time since its last switch, and we compare its ends with its center for every exponent $\alpha > 0$. The steps form maximal runs whose directions alternate. The first run has length $D$, and the later runs have i.i.d. lengths $\xi_1, \xi_2, \dots$ distributed as $\xi$, where

$$\bar{F}(k) = \mathbb{P}(\xi \geq k) = k^{-\alpha} \quad (k \geq 1)$$

for some $\alpha > 0$. So $\mathbb{P}(\xi = k) = k^{-\alpha} - (k+1)^{-\alpha} > 0$ for every $k \geq 1$. The first direction is fair, and $D$, $(\xi_i)$ and the first direction are independent.

With a fresh start $D$ has the law of $\xi$. For $\alpha > 1$ the stationary start is $\mathbb{P}(D = \ell) = \bar{F}(\ell)/\mu$, where $\mu = \mathbb{E}\xi = \zeta(\alpha)$. This law is stationary in the following sense. The number of steps left in the current run, counting the current one, is a Markov chain that moves from $k \geq 2$ to $k-1$ and from 1 to a fresh copy of $\xi$. Since $\bar{F}(k) = \bar{F}(k+1) + \mathbb{P}(\xi = k)\bar{F}(1)$, the law $\bar{F}(k)/\mu$ is invariant for this chain. So the stationary start sees the runs at a typical time. We define $A_N$, $P_N$, $C_N$, $E_N$ and $R_N = E_N/C_N$ as in Section 1.2. In this section the constants implied by $O(\cdot)$ may depend on $\alpha$.

**Proposition 2.1** (the end)**.** *For every law of $D$ and every $N \geq 1$, $E_N = \frac{1}{2}\mathbb{P}(D \geq N)$. With a fresh start $E_N = \frac{1}{2}N^{-\alpha}$. With the stationary start*

$$E_N = \frac{\zeta(\alpha, N)}{2\zeta(\alpha)} = \frac{N^{1-\alpha}}{2(\alpha-1)\zeta(\alpha)}\Big(1 + \frac{\vartheta_N(\alpha-1)}{N}\Big)$$

*for some $\vartheta_N \in [0,1]$, where $\zeta(\alpha, N) = \sum_{k \geq N} k^{-\alpha}$ is the Hurwitz zeta function.*

*Proof.* All $N$ steps are $+1$ exactly when the first direction is $+$ and $D \geq N$. Hence $E_N = \frac{1}{2}\mathbb{P}(D \geq N)$. For the fresh start $\mathbb{P}(D \geq N) = \bar{F}(N) = N^{-\alpha}$. For the stationary start $\mathbb{P}(D \geq N) = \sum_{\ell \geq N} \ell^{-\alpha}/\mu = \zeta(\alpha, N)/\zeta(\alpha)$. To estimate $\zeta(\alpha, N)$ we compare the sum with an integral. Since $t^{-\alpha}$ is decreasing,

$$\int_N^\infty t^{-\alpha}\, dt \leq \zeta(\alpha, N) \leq N^{-\alpha} + \int_N^\infty t^{-\alpha}\, dt.$$

The integral equals $N^{1-\alpha}/(\alpha-1)$, and $N^{-\alpha}$ is $(\alpha-1)/N$ times the integral. This gives the second form. □

So the end only sees the first run, while the center depends on all the runs. For the center we need the renewal quantities

$$\tau_m = \xi_1 + \cdots + \xi_m, \quad \tau_0 = 0, \qquad u_m(k) = \mathbb{P}(\tau_m = k),$$
$$q_m(k) = \mathbb{P}(\tau_{m-1} < k \leq \tau_m) = \sum_{j \geq 1} \bar{F}(j) u_{m-1}(k-j)$$

for $m, k \geq 1$. So $u_m(k)$ is the chance that the $m$-th run ends at level $k$, and $q_m(k)$ the chance that the $m$-th run covers level $k$. For the delayed versions let $D$ be independent of $(\xi_i)$, and put $u_m^D(k) = \mathbb{P}(D + \tau_{m-1} = k)$, $q_1^D(k) = \mathbb{P}(D \geq k)$ and $q_m^D(k) = \mathbb{P}(D + \tau_{m-2} < k \leq D + \tau_{m-1})$ for $m \geq 2$. For the stationary start $u_m^D(k) = \sum_\ell \frac{\bar{F}(\ell)}{\mu} u_{m-1}(k-\ell) = q_m(k)/\mu$.

The $+$ runs and the $-$ runs form two independent renewal processes. For $1 \leq a \leq N-1$ the walk is in bin $a$ at time $N$ exactly when one process has a run that ends exactly at its level ($a$ for the $+$ runs and $N-a$ for the $-$ runs) and the other process has a run that covers its level.

**Proposition 2.2** (two renewal processes)**.** *Let $D$ have any law on $\{1,2,\dots\}$. For $a+b=N$ with $a,b\ge 1$,*

$$\mathbb{P}_+(A_N=a)=\sum_{m\ge 1}\Big[u_m(b)\,q^D_{m+1}(a)+u^D_m(a)\,q_m(b)\Big],$$

*and $\mathbb{P}_+(A_N=N)=\mathbb{P}(D\ge N)$. So for even $N$ and $h=N/2$, $C_N=\sum_{m\ge1}[u_m(h)q^D_{m+1}(h)+u^D_m(h)q_m(h)]$. For the fresh start this is $C_N=\sum_m u_m(h)[q_m(h)+q_{m+1}(h)]$.*

*Proof.* We split according to the run that contains step $N$. Let the + runs have lengths $D,\xi^+_2,\xi^+_3,\dots$ and the − runs $\xi^-_1,\xi^-_2,\dots$, and let $s^\pm_j$ be the sum of the first $j$ lengths of each sign, with $s^\pm_0=0$. So $s^+_j$ has law $u^D_j$ and $s^-_j$ has law $u_j$, and the two sequences are independent. The runs alternate and the first one is a + run. So the $j$-th + run comes after $j-1$ runs of each sign and covers the steps in $(s^+_{j-1}+s^-_{j-1},\, s^+_j+s^-_{j-1}]$, and the $j$-th − run covers $(s^+_j+s^-_{j-1},\, s^+_j+s^-_j]$. Let $N=a+b$. There are three cases.

Suppose step $N$ is in the first run. Then $A_N=N$, and this happens exactly when $D\ge N$.

Suppose step $N$ is in the $j$-th + run with $j\ge 2$. Then exactly $j-1$ of the − runs lie before step $N$, and they are complete, so $A_N=N-s^-_{j-1}$. So $A_N=a$ means $s^-_{j-1}=b$, and then step $N=a+b$ is in this run exactly when $s^+_{j-1}<a\le s^+_j$. By independence this has probability $u_{j-1}(b)\,q^D_j(a)$.

Suppose step $N$ is in the $j$-th − run. Then the first $j$ of the + runs are complete and no other has begun, so $A_N=s^+_j$. So $A_N=a$ means $s^+_j=a$, and then step $N$ is in this run exactly when $s^-_{j-1}<b\le s^-_j$. This has probability $u^D_j(a)\,q_j(b)$.

The cases are disjoint. Summing them, with $m=j-1$ in the second and $m=j$ in the third, gives the formula. Now let $N$ be even. The first direction is fair, and changing the sign of every step sends $A_N$ to $N-A_N$. Hence $C_N=\frac12[\mathbb{P}_+(A_N=h)+\mathbb{P}_+(A_N=N-h)]=\mathbb{P}_+(A_N=h)$. With a fresh start $u^D_m=u_m$ and $q^D_m=q_m$, which gives the last formula. □

For a fresh start this identity is the coefficient form of the double transform of Godrèche and Luck [4, Section 7] for the occupation time of an alternating renewal process. A general first run only changes the factors $u^D_m$ and $q^D_{m+1}$. To evaluate the sum we need the stable limit of $\tau_m$ and its local form.

**Lemma 2.3** (stable and local limits)**.** *Let $1<\alpha<2$ and $a_m=m^{1/\alpha}$. Put $K_\alpha=\Gamma(2-\alpha)/(\alpha-1)=-\Gamma(1-\alpha)>0$ and $\sigma_\alpha=2K_\alpha|\cos\frac{\pi\alpha}{2}|$.*

*(i)* $\mathbb{E}e^{i\theta\xi}=1+i\mu\theta+K_\alpha(-i\theta)^\alpha+O(\theta^2)$ *as $\theta\to0$, with the principal branch.*

*(ii) $(\tau_m-m\mu)/a_m$ converges in law to a variable $G$ with $\mathbb{E}e^{i\theta G}=\exp(K_\alpha(-i\theta)^\alpha)$. The law of $G$ has a bounded, uniformly continuous density $g$ with $g(z)\to0$ as $|z|\to\infty$.*

*(iii) (Gnedenko) The constant $\bar u:=\sup_{m\ge1}\sup_k a_m u_m(k)$ is finite, and $a_m u_m(k)-g((k-m\mu)/a_m)\to0$ uniformly in $k$ as $m\to\infty$.*

*(iv) If $G'$ is an independent copy of $G$, then $G-G'$ is symmetric $\alpha$-stable with $\mathbb{E}e^{i\theta(G-G')}=e^{-\sigma_\alpha|\theta|^\alpha}$, and $I_\alpha:=\int_{\mathbb{R}}g(z)^2\,dz=\Gamma(1+1/\alpha)/(\pi\sigma_\alpha^{1/\alpha})$.*

*Proof.* All four parts come from the expansion of the transform of $\xi$ near 0. We find it first.

(i) Summation by parts gives $1-\mathbb{E}w^\xi=(1-w)\sum_{k\ge1}\bar F(k)w^{k-1}$ for $|w|\le1$. Put $w=e^{-v}$ with $\operatorname{Re}v\ge0$, and write $\operatorname{Li}_\alpha(w)=\sum_{k\ge1}k^{-\alpha}w^k$. Since $\bar F(k)=k^{-\alpha}$, the identity reads $1-\mathbb{E}e^{-v\xi}=$

$(e^v-1)\mathrm{Li}_\alpha(e^{-v})$. For $0<|v|<2\pi$, [19, 25.12.12] gives $\mathrm{Li}_\alpha(e^{-v})=\Gamma(1-\alpha)v^{\alpha-1}+\zeta(\alpha)+O(|v|)$. We multiply by $e^v-1=v+O(|v|^2)$ and use $\zeta(\alpha)=\mu$ and $\Gamma(1-\alpha)=-K_\alpha$. Since $\alpha+1>2$,

$$1-\mathbb{E}e^{-v\xi}=\mu v-K_\alpha v^\alpha+O(|v|^2)\qquad(v\to 0,\ \operatorname{Re} v\ge 0).$$

With $v=-i\theta$ this is (i).

(ii) Put $Z_m=(\tau_m-m\mu)/a_m$. Fix $\theta$ and let $t=\theta/a_m$. By (i) and $e^{-i\mu t}=1-i\mu t+O(t^2)$, and since $a_m^\alpha=m$,

$$e^{-i\mu t}\,\mathbb{E}e^{it\xi}=1+K_\alpha(-it)^\alpha+O(t^2)=1+\frac{K_\alpha(-i\theta)^\alpha}{m}+O\big(\theta^2 m^{-2/\alpha}\big).$$

The left side is the characteristic function of $(\xi-\mu)/a_m$ at $\theta$, and $\mathbb{E}e^{i\theta Z_m}$ is its $m$-th power. As $2/\alpha>1$, the error is $o(1/m)$, so $\mathbb{E}e^{i\theta Z_m}\to\exp(K_\alpha(-i\theta)^\alpha)$. The real part of $(-i\theta)^\alpha$ is $|\theta|^\alpha\cos\frac{\pi\alpha}{2}$, which is negative because $1<\alpha<2$. So the limit has modulus $\exp(-\frac12\sigma_\alpha|\theta|^\alpha)$. It is continuous at 0, so by Lévy's continuity theorem it is the characteristic function of a variable $G$, and $Z_m$ converges in law to $G$. This characteristic function is integrable, so by Fourier inversion $G$ has a bounded, uniformly continuous density $g$, and $g$ vanishes at infinity by the Riemann–Lebesgue lemma (the domain of attraction also follows from [17, Section XVII.5]).

(iii) Every $\mathbb{P}(\xi=k)$ is positive, so $\xi$ has maximal span 1. So Gnedenko's local limit theorem [14, Theorem 4.2.1] applies to the convergence in (ii) and gives the uniform limit. For $\bar u$, the limit gives an $m_0$ with $a_m u_m(k)\le\|g\|_\infty+1$ for all $m\ge m_0$ and all $k$. For $m<m_0$ we use $u_m(k)\le 1$, so $a_m u_m(k)\le a_{m_0}$. Hence $\bar u<\infty$.

(iv) The characteristic function of $-G'$ is the complex conjugate of that of $G$. So $G-G'$ has the characteristic function $|\mathbb{E}e^{i\theta G}|^2=e^{-\sigma_\alpha|\theta|^\alpha}$, which is that of a symmetric $\alpha$-stable law. Plancherel's theorem gives

$$I_\alpha=\int_{\mathbb{R}}g(z)^2\,dz=\frac{1}{2\pi}\int_{\mathbb{R}}e^{-\sigma_\alpha|\theta|^\alpha}\,d\theta=\frac{1}{\pi}\int_0^\infty e^{-\sigma_\alpha\theta^\alpha}\,d\theta=\frac{\Gamma(1+1/\alpha)}{\pi\sigma_\alpha^{1/\alpha}},$$

where the last step is the substitution $x=\sigma_\alpha\theta^\alpha$. (Note that $I_\alpha$ is the density of $G-G'$ at 0. This is how it enters Theorem 2.4, where two independent renewal processes have to meet.) □

**Theorem 2.4** (the center for $1<\alpha<2$)**.** *Let $1<\alpha<2$ and let $D$ be any a.s. finite first run, in particular either start. As $N\to\infty$ over even $N$,*

$$C_N\sim 2I_\alpha\Big(\frac{\mu}{h}\Big)^{1/\alpha}=\frac{2\Gamma(1+1/\alpha)}{\pi}\Big(\frac{\mu}{K_\alpha|\cos(\pi\alpha/2)|\,N}\Big)^{1/\alpha}.$$

In words, the center decays like $N^{-1/\alpha}$, and the first run does not affect the leading term.

**Idea of the proof.** By Proposition 2.2 the walk ends in the center when, for some $m$, one renewal process ends its $m$-th run exactly at level $h$ and the other is inside a run that covers level $h$. Level $h$ takes about $h/\mu$ runs. Put $b_h=(h/\mu)^{1/\alpha}$, which is the scale on which $\tau_m$ spreads around its mean for such $m$. So the $m$-th run ends at $h$ with probability about $g(z)/b_h$, where $z=(h-m\mu)/b_h$ says how far $m$ is from the typical number of runs. A level is covered by a run $\mu$ times as often as a run ends there, so the $m$-th run covers $h$ with probability about $\mu g(z)/b_h$. The values of $m$ that matter have $|m\mu-h|$ of order $b_h$, and there are $b_h/\mu$ of them for each unit of $z$. Proposition 2.2 has two terms of this kind for each $m$, so $C_N$ is about $2\cdot\frac{1}{b_h}\cdot\frac{\mu}{b_h}\cdot\frac{b_h}{\mu}\int g^2=2I_\alpha/b_h$. The proof is in Appendices A.1 to A.3.

| $\alpha$ | $e(\alpha)$ | $C(\alpha)$ | $C_{\mathrm{fr}}(\alpha)$ | $R_{1600}$ | $R_{10^4}$ | $R_{10^5}$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1.3 | +0.469231 | 0.422717 | 0.498631 | 17.7593 [1.3180] | 38.7537 [1.2171] | 106.149 [1.1317] |
| 1.5 | +0.166667 | 0.647971 | 0.846371 | 2.14409 [0.9675] | 2.95280 [0.9818] | 4.37642 [0.9914] |
| $\varphi$ | 0 | 0.776132 | 1.073675 | 0.661763 [0.8526] | 0.697331 [0.8985] | 0.727689 [0.9376] |
| 5/3 | $-1/15$ | 0.835101 | 1.182237 | 0.411815 [0.8064] | 0.389307 [0.8614] | 0.352822 [0.9102] |
| 1.7 | −0.111765 | 0.880046 | 1.265508 | 0.298369 [0.7733] | 0.262005 [0.8334] | 0.215839 [0.8881] |
| 1.9 | −0.373684 | 1.438986 | 2.266075 | 0.0449706 [0.4923] | 0.0256505 [0.5569] | 0.0121612 [0.6242] |

Table 1: Constants of Corollary 2.5 and computed values of $R_N = E_N/C_N$ for the stationary start, with $R_N/(C(\alpha)N^{e(\alpha)})$ in brackets.

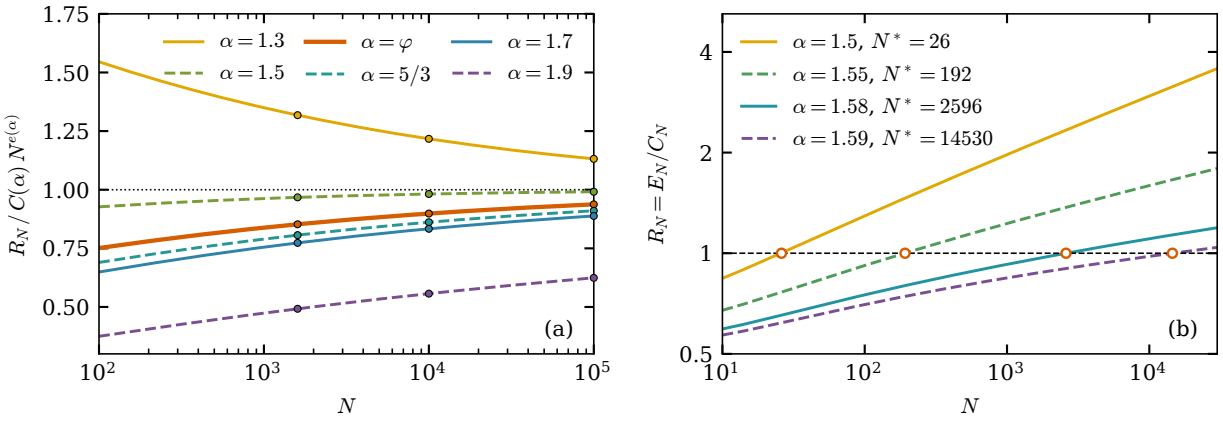



Figure 1: Alternating runs with a stationary start. (a) $R_N/(C(\alpha)N^{e(\alpha)})$ for even $N$ from 100 to $10^5$, with the entries of Table 1 as dots. (b) $R_N$ for $\alpha = 1.5, 1.55, 1.58, 1.59$ below $\varphi$. Each curve crosses 1 once on $10 \le N \le 3 \cdot 10^4$, at $N^*(\alpha)$ (circles).

**Corollary 2.5** (the golden-ratio exponent)**.** *Let $1 < \alpha < 2$ and $e(\alpha) = 1 - \alpha + 1/\alpha$. If $\mathbb{P}(D \ge N) \sim c_D N^{-\beta_D}$ with $c_D, \beta_D > 0$, then $R_N \sim c_D N^{1/\alpha - \beta_D}/(4I_\alpha(2\mu)^{1/\alpha})$. In particular $R_N \sim C(\alpha)N^{e(\alpha)}$ for the stationary start and $R_N \sim C_{\mathrm{fr}}(\alpha)N^{e(\alpha)-1}$ for the fresh start, where*

$$C(\alpha) = \frac{\pi\big(K_\alpha|\cos\tfrac{\pi\alpha}{2}|\big)^{1/\alpha}}{4(\alpha-1)\Gamma(1+\frac{1}{\alpha})\,\zeta(\alpha)^{1+1/\alpha}}, \qquad C_{\mathrm{fr}}(\alpha) = (\alpha-1)\zeta(\alpha)\,C(\alpha).$$

*Since $e(\alpha) > 0$ exactly when $\alpha < \varphi$, with a stationary start the ends win for all large $N$ if $\alpha < \varphi$, and the center wins if $\alpha > \varphi$. At $\alpha = \varphi$,*

$$R_N \to C(\varphi) = \frac{\pi\varphi\big(\varphi\,\Gamma(\varphi^{-2})|\cos\tfrac{\pi\varphi}{2}|\big)^{1/\varphi}}{4\,\Gamma(\varphi)\,\zeta(\varphi)^{\varphi}} = 0.7761317206\ldots,$$

*so the center still wins, by the factor $1/C(\varphi) = 1.2884\ldots$ in the limit. That $C(\varphi) < 1$ needs no computation (see the proof). With a fresh start $e(\alpha) - 1 < 0$, and the center wins for every $1 < \alpha < 2$.*

*Proof.* We prove the general formula, then read off the two starts, and then treat $\alpha = \varphi$. By Proposition 2.1 and Theorem 2.4, with $h = N/2$, we have $R_N = \mathbb{P}(D \ge N)/(2C_N)$, and this is asymptotic to $c_D N^{-\beta_D}/(4I_\alpha(2\mu/N)^{1/\alpha})$, which is the general formula. By Lemma 2.3(iv), $4I_\alpha(2\mu)^{1/\alpha} = 4\Gamma(1+\frac{1}{\alpha})\mu^{1/\alpha}/(\pi(K_\alpha|\cos\frac{\pi\alpha}{2}|)^{1/\alpha})$. The fresh start has $c_D = 1$ and $\beta_D = \alpha$, which

| $\alpha$ | start | center $C_N$ | ratio $R_N$ | status |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| $\alpha > 2$ | stationary | $\sim \sqrt{2\mu/(\pi v N)}$ | $\sim C_2(\alpha) N^{3/2-\alpha} \to 0$ | Theorem 2.7(a) |
| $\alpha = 2$ | stationary | $\sim \sqrt{2\mu/(\pi N \log N)}$ | $\sim \sqrt{\pi \log N/(8\zeta(2)^3 N)} \to 0$ | Theorem 2.7(b) |
| $1 < \alpha < 2$ | stationary | $\sim 2I_\alpha(\mu/h)^{1/\alpha}$ | $\sim C(\alpha) N^{e(\alpha)}$ | Corollary 2.5 |
| $1 < \alpha < 2$ | fresh | $\sim 2I_\alpha(\mu/h)^{1/\alpha}$ | $\sim C_{\mathrm{fr}}(\alpha) N^{e(\alpha)-1} \to 0$ | Corollary 2.5 |
| $\alpha = 1$ | fresh | $\approx 2/(\pi^2 \tilde{m}_h)$ | $\approx \pi^2 \tilde{m}_h/(8h) \sim \pi^2/(8 \log N)$ | heuristic, not proved (Remark 2.9) |
| $0 < \alpha < 1$ | fresh | $\sim \frac{2}{\pi} \tan \frac{\pi\alpha}{2} \cdot \frac{1}{N}$ | $\sim \frac{\pi}{4 \tan(\pi\alpha/2)} N^{1-\alpha} \to \infty$ | Theorem 2.8 |

Table 2: The center and the ratio $R_N = E_N/C_N$ for each exponent. The center wins when $R_N \to 0$ and the ends win when $R_N \to \infty$. For $\alpha \geq 2$ the center formula holds for every a.s. finite first run, and a fresh start also gives $R_N \to 0$.

gives $C_{\mathrm{fr}}(\alpha)$. By Proposition 2.1 the stationary start has $c_D = 1/((\alpha-1)\mu)$ and $\beta_D = \alpha - 1$, which gives $C(\alpha)$. Next, $e(\alpha) = -(\alpha^2 - \alpha - 1)/\alpha$, and $\varphi$ is the positive root of $\alpha^2 - \alpha - 1$. At $\alpha = \varphi$ we have $\alpha - 1 = 1/\varphi$, $1 + 1/\alpha = \varphi$ and $2 - \alpha = \varphi^{-2}$. So $K_\varphi = \varphi\,\Gamma(\varphi^{-2})$, and substituting these into $C(\alpha)$ gives the closed form. To see that $C(\varphi) < 1$, we use four elementary bounds. Since $x^{-\varphi}$ is convex, the trapezoid rule overestimates its integral over $[1, \infty)$, so $\zeta(\varphi) - \frac{1}{2} \geq 1/(\varphi - 1) = \varphi$. The minimum of $\Gamma$ on $(0, \infty)$ is $0.8856\ldots$ [19, Section 5.4(iii)], so $\Gamma(\varphi) \geq 0.8856$. Since $\Gamma \leq 1$ on $[1, 2]$, $\Gamma(\varphi^{-2}) = \Gamma(1 + \varphi^{-2})\varphi^2 \leq \varphi^2$. Finally $\frac{\pi}{2} < \frac{\pi\varphi}{2} < \frac{5\pi}{6}$, so $|\cos \frac{\pi\varphi}{2}| \leq \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}$. Together these give $C(\varphi) \leq \pi\varphi(\sqrt{3}\varphi^3/2)^{1/\varphi}/(4 \cdot 0.8856\,(\varphi + \frac{1}{2})^\varphi) = 0.95136\ldots < 1$. □

Corollary 2.5 is the lattice form, with its constant, of the heuristic of [12, Section 6.2.1.3, Eq. (6.49)]. The approach to $C(\varphi)$ is slow. At $\alpha = \varphi$ we have $R_{10^5}/C(\varphi) = 0.938$, and $R_N$ increases at every even $N$ from 10 to $10^5$ (Table 1 and Figure 1). At the value $\alpha = 5/3$ of Lévy-walk models of heat conduction [9, 8, 7], $R_N \sim C(5/3)N^{-1/15}$ with $C(5/3) = 0.8351$.

*Remark* 2.6 (broadened side peaks). With velocity fluctuations the ballistic side peaks of a Lévy walk broaden into humps. If the speed is redrawn at each collision, the humps have width of order $t$ and height of order $t^{-\alpha}$, and if it fluctuates during each flight, they have width of order $t^{1/2}$ and height of order $t^{1/2-\alpha}$ [6, Table I]. As a heuristic, matching these heights with the height $t^{-1/\alpha}$ of the central peak [12, Section 6.2.1.3, Eq. (6.49)] gives $\alpha = 1$ in the first case, so the center wins for every $1 < \alpha < 2$, and in the second case the root $\alpha = (1 + \sqrt{17})/4 = 1.28\ldots$ of $\alpha^2 - \alpha/2 - 1 = 0$. The golden ratio belongs to the unbroadened peaks, which our lattice walk has.

We turn to the other exponents. Table 2 collects them. For $\alpha \geq 2$ the sums $\tau_m$ have a Gaussian limit, and the center wins with either start.

**Theorem 2.7** ($\alpha \geq 2$)**.** *Let $D$ be any a.s. finite first run, and let $N \to \infty$ over even $N$.*

*(a) Let $\alpha > 2$ and $v = \operatorname{Var} \xi = 2\zeta(\alpha - 1) - \zeta(\alpha) - \zeta(\alpha)^2$. Then $C_N \sim \sqrt{2\mu/(\pi v N)}$. With the stationary start $R_N \sim C_2(\alpha) N^{3/2-\alpha}$, where $C_2(\alpha) = \sqrt{\pi v/(2\mu)}/(2(\alpha-1)\mu)$.*

*(b) Let $\alpha = 2$, so that $\mu = \zeta(2)$ and $\mathbb{E}\xi^2 = \infty$. Then $(\tau_m - m\mu)/\sqrt{m \log m}$ converges in law to the standard normal law, and $C_N \sim \sqrt{2\mu/(\pi N \log N)}$. With the stationary start $R_N \sim \sqrt{\pi \log N/(8\zeta(2)^3 N)}$.*

*In both cases $R_N \to 0$ with the fresh start too.*

The exponent of $R_N$ is continuous at $\alpha = 2$, since $e(2) = -\frac{1}{2} = \frac{3}{2} - 2$. The proof of Theorem 2.4 in Appendix A is written so that it covers this theorem too, with the normal law in place of the stable law (Appendix A.4).

The convergence is slow at $\alpha = 2$. There $R_N$ divided by the leading term in (b) is 0.885 at $N = 1600$ and 0.943 at $N = 10^5$. At $\alpha = 3$ the ratio of $R_N$ to the leading term in (a) is 0.981 at $N = 16000$.

For $0 < \alpha < 1$ the runs have infinite mean, and only the fresh start makes sense. Then $A_N/N$ has a limit law that is not concentrated at a point, namely Lamperti's occupation-time law [5, 4], with density

$$\ell_\alpha(y) = \frac{\sin \pi\alpha}{\pi} \frac{y^{\alpha-1}(1-y)^{\alpha-1}}{y^{2\alpha} + 2y^\alpha(1-y)^\alpha \cos \pi\alpha + (1-y)^{2\alpha}} \qquad (0 < y < 1).$$

So the center should be of order $1/N$. The next theorem is the local form of this at the center.

**Theorem 2.8** $(0 < \alpha < 1)$**.** *Let $0 < \alpha < 1$, with a fresh start. As $N \to \infty$ over even $N$,*

$$NC_N \to \ell_\alpha(\tfrac{1}{2}) = \frac{2}{\pi} \tan \frac{\pi\alpha}{2}.$$

*Hence $R_N \sim \frac{\pi}{4 \tan(\pi\alpha/2)} N^{1-\alpha} \to \infty$.*

In words, for $\alpha < 1$ the center is an ordinary bin of size about $1/N$, while the end has the much larger probability $\frac{1}{2}N^{-\alpha}$ that the first run goes right and lasts all $N$ steps. So the ends win for every $\alpha < 1$. For the continuum Lévy walk with $0 < \alpha < 1$, the ballistic regime, Froemberg et al. [11] find the asymptotic densities.

**Idea of the proof.** Now $\tau_m$ is of order $m^{1/\alpha}$ with no centering, and the number of runs of each sign is no longer concentrated, so the sum over it becomes an integral (Appendix A.5). The proof does not use Lamperti's theorem.

Here too the convergence is slow near $\alpha = 1$. At $N = 16000$ the ratio of $NC_N$ to its limit is 1.042, 1.001, 0.928 and 0.554 for $\alpha = 0.3$, 0.5, 0.7 and 0.9. We do not prove the local limit at bins other than the center.

*Remark* 2.9 (the exponent $\alpha = 1$ and the fresh start). With a fresh start the threshold is $\alpha = 1$. The ends win for $\alpha < 1$ by Theorem 2.8, and the center wins for $\alpha > 1$ by Corollary 2.5 and Theorem 2.7. At $\alpha = 1$ we only have a heuristic. Suppose we repeat the proof of Theorem 2.4 with a skewed Cauchy limit, the centering $m(H_{m+1} - 1)$, and the density $1/\pi^2$ at 0 of the difference of two copies of the limit. This suggests the row of Table 2, namely $R_N \approx \pi^2 \tilde{m}_h/(8h) \sim \pi^2/(8 \log N)$, where $\tilde{m}_h$ solves $m(H_{m+1} - 1) = h$. We have not controlled the error terms, so the claim that the center wins by a logarithm at $\alpha = 1$ is not proved. The computed $R_N$ divided by $\pi^2 \tilde{m}_h/(8h)$ is 0.796, 0.850 and 0.886 at $N = 1600$, $10^4$ and $10^5$.

We do not know a rate in Theorem 2.4, whether $R_N$ is monotone with a single sign change of $R_N - 1$, how to make the case $\alpha = 1$ rigorous, or the full shape of $P_N$ for heavy-tailed runs.

## 3 Aging walks

In this section the walk remembers its age. After its first step it switches direction at step $k \geq 2$ with probability $c/k$, independently of the past, where $0 < c < 2$. So the walk switches less and less often, and the expected number of switches in $N$ steps is $c(H_N - 1)$, which is about $c \log N$. With a fair first step, $A_N/N$ converges in law to Beta$(c, c)$ [20, Example 1.1 and Theorem 1.4], [21, Theorem 1]. At finite $N$ the first step matters. We first give one exact law behind all the ties, then fix the first step, pass to $d$ states, and return to the fair first step.

We write $\mathbb{P}_+$ for the law given $X_1 = +1$, as in Section 1.2, and $X_N$ for the last step. A path is a sequence $x \in \{\pm 1\}^N$, and it switches at time $t \geq 2$ if $x_t \neq x_{t-1}$. Step $k \geq 2$ contributes the factor $c/k$ to the probability of a path if the path switches there, and $1 - c/k$ otherwise. So relative to no switch, a switch at time $t$ multiplies the probability of a path by the odds

$$\omega_t = \frac{c/t}{1 - c/t} = \frac{c}{t - c} \qquad (t \geq 2),$$

and

$$\mathbb{P}_+(X = x) = \prod_{k=2}^{N} \Big(1 - \frac{c}{k}\Big) \prod_{t:\, x_t \neq x_{t-1}} \omega_t \qquad (x_1 = +1). \tag{1}$$

Each $\omega_t$ is positive and continuous on $(0, 2)$, increases strictly in $c$, and tends to 0 as $c \downarrow 0$.

### 3.1 Drawing afresh or repeating

All the exact laws of this section come from one chain, which works for every weight. Fix $d \geq 2$ and $\theta > 0$, and let $Y_1, Y_2, \ldots$ be the following chain on $\{1, \ldots, d\}$. At step $t \geq 1$, with probability

$$f_t = \frac{d\theta}{d\theta + t - 1}$$

the state $Y_t$ is drawn afresh, uniformly from the $d$ states, and otherwise $Y_t = Y_{t-1}$ (so $Y_1$ is uniform, since $f_1 = 1$). In other words, at step $t \geq 2$ the chain moves to each other state with probability $\theta/(d\theta + t - 1)$. This is the mechanism of the conservative random walk of Engländer and Volkov [27], who redraw a direction in $\mathbb{Z}^d$ with probability $p_n$ and study recurrence and scaling limits. Let $M_T$ be the vector of visit counts of $Y_1, \ldots, Y_T$, and write $x^{(m)} = x(x+1)\cdots(x+m-1)$.

**Proposition 3.1** (fresh or repeat)**.** *For every $T \geq 1$, every composition $m$ of $T$ into $d$ nonnegative parts and every state $j$,*

$$\mathbb{P}(M_T = m,\, Y_T = j) = \frac{m_j}{T}\, Q_T(m), \qquad Q_T(m) = \frac{T!}{(d\theta)^{(T)}} \prod_{i=1}^{d} \frac{\theta^{(m_i)}}{m_i!}. \tag{2}$$

*So $M_T$ has the law $Q_T$ of the counts in Pólya's urn with $d$ colors and initial weight $\theta$ on each color. For $d = 2$ and even $T$,*

$$\frac{\mathbb{P}(M_T = (T/2, T/2))}{\mathbb{P}(M_T = (T, 0))} = \binom{T}{T/2} \prod_{i=0}^{T/2-1} \frac{\theta + i}{\theta + T/2 + i}, \tag{3}$$

*which increases strictly in $\theta$ and equals 1 exactly at $\theta = 1$.*

In words, the chain repeats its last state where the urn repeats a uniformly chosen earlier draw, and at each fixed time this makes no difference to the counts or to the last state. The whole law is explicit on both sides of the tie (Figure 2).

*Proof.* We use induction on $T$. For $T = 1$ both sides of (2) are $\frac{1}{d}$ when $m = e_j$ and 0 otherwise. Let $T \geq 2$ and suppose (2) holds for $T - 1$. If $m_j = 0$ both sides vanish. Otherwise put $m' = m - e_j$. Summing (2) over the last state gives $\mathbb{P}(M_{T-1} = m') = Q_{T-1}(m')$. A fresh draw gives $j$ with

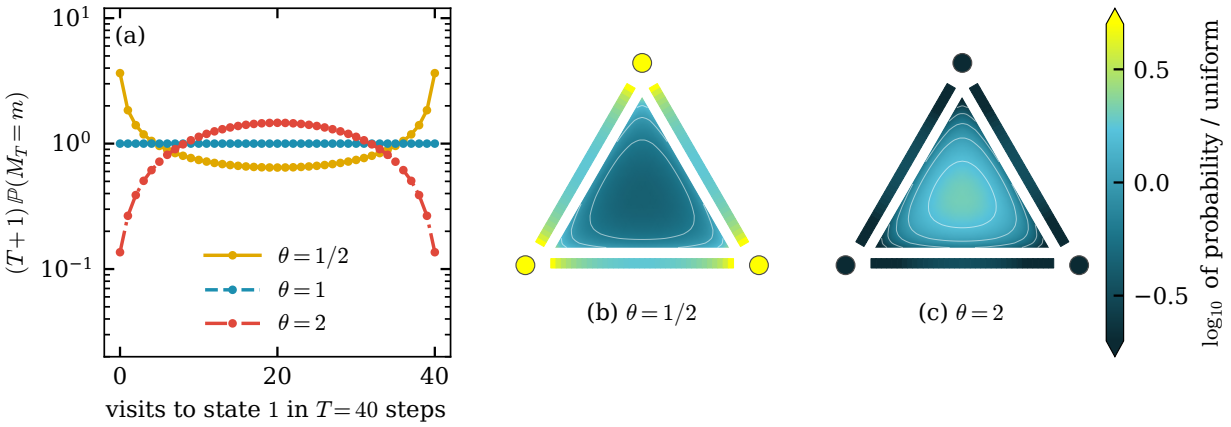



Figure 2: The exact law (2) of the counts of the chain that draws afresh or repeats. (a) Two states and $T = 40$, as a multiple of the uniform law. The law is flat at $\theta = 1$, the ends are the most likely bins for $\theta = \frac{1}{2}$, and the center is for $\theta = 2$. (b), (c) Three states and $T = 36$ on the simplex of visit fractions, colored by the probability of a bin relative to the uniform law. The triangle holds the bins that use all three states, the bands hold the bins that use two, and the disks are the bins that use one. The thin lines are level lines. For $\theta = \frac{1}{2}$ a corner is 9.6 times as likely as under the uniform law and the center 0.43 times. For $\theta = 2$ the numbers are 0.035 and 2.1.

probability $\frac{1}{d}$ whatever the last state was, and a repeat gives $j$ only when the last state was $j$ (this is why the induction carries the last state along with the counts). So

$$\mathbb{P}(M_T = m,\, Y_T = j) = \frac{f_T}{d}\, Q_{T-1}(m') + (1 - f_T)\, \frac{m_j - 1}{T - 1}\, Q_{T-1}(m') = \frac{\theta + m_j - 1}{d\theta + T - 1}\, Q_{T-1}(m').$$

On the other hand $Q_T(m) = Q_{T-1}(m') \cdot \frac{T}{m_j} \cdot \frac{\theta + m_j - 1}{d\theta + T - 1}$ by the definition of $Q_T$. This gives (2). Summing over $j$ gives $\mathbb{P}(M_T = m) = Q_T(m)$, and the ratio (3) is $Q_T(T/2, T/2)/Q_T(T, 0)$ with $\theta^{(T)} = \theta^{(T/2)}(\theta + T/2)^{(T/2)}$. Each factor $(\theta + i)/(\theta + T/2 + i)$ increases strictly in $\theta$, and at $\theta = 1$ the product is $(T/2)!^2/T!$. □

The law of the counts alone is known. Dietz, Lippitt and Sethuraman [24, Theorem 2.18] show that the moments of the limit law of the chains of [20] are occupation probabilities at finite $N$ of a second chain. In the case of a Dirichlet limit that second chain is $Y$, with the uniform law in the role of their $\mu$ and $d\theta$ in the role of their $\theta$. The limit is then the Dirichlet law with every parameter $\theta$ [20, Theorem 1.4], and its moments give $Q_T$. Engländer and Volkov work it out in Chapter 7 of their March 18, 2024 draft. For two states and an integer weight $\theta$ they prove (2), with the last state, for every $T$ (author draft, Theorem 7.2, pp. 138–139), and they credit this result to E. Crane. What the proposition adds is the joint law with the last state for $d \geq 3$ states, and for a weight $\theta$ that is not an integer. As $T \to \infty$, (2) turns into the joint limit of the fractions of time and the current state found by Bouguet and Cloez [23, Proposition 4.1], in which the Dirichlet law is size-biased by the coordinate of the current state.

*Remark* 3.2. Here is another way to see the law of the counts in Proposition 3.1 (but not the joint law with the last state). The fresh draws cut $Y_1, \ldots, Y_T$ into runs, and each run gets a uniform state. The urn can be run in the same way, as a Chinese restaurant process in which each table gets a uniform color. There a table is opened with the same probabilities $f_t$. The lengths of the runs are the spacings between the successes of independent trials with success

probabilities $f_t$. It is a classical fact (the Feller coupling, see [22]) that the multiset of these spacings has the same law as the multiset of the table sizes (the two ordered lists do not). The proof in (author draft, Section 7.4), like Proposition 3.1, instead goes through the last state. We checked (2) in exact arithmetic for four values of $\theta$, with $T \le 7$ for $d = 2, 3$ and $T \le 5$ for $d = 4$ (`verify_aging_urn.py`).

### 3.2 A fixed first step

Here the walk starts with a step $+1$.

**Proposition 3.3** (two states, fixed first step)**.** *Let $N \ge 2$ and let the first step be $+1$.*

*(a) At $c = 1$, for $1 \le s \le N$,*

$$\mathbb{P}_+(A_N = s,\, X_N = +1) = \frac{s-1}{N(N-1)}, \qquad \mathbb{P}_+(A_N = s,\, X_N = -1) = \frac{N-s}{N(N-1)}.$$

*So $A_N$ is uniform on $\{1, \dots, N\}$.*

*(b) For $1 \le s \le N-1$ the ratio $\mathbb{P}_+(A_N = s)/\mathbb{P}_+(A_N = N)$ increases strictly in $c \in (0, 2)$, and it equals 1 exactly at $c = 1$.*

For $c < 1$ the end bin is the most likely bin, and for $c > 1$ it is the least likely of the bins $1, \dots, N$ (bin 0 has probability 0).

*Proof.* (a) At $c = 1$, the shifted chain $Y_t = X_{t+1}$ is the chain of Proposition 3.1 with $d = 2$, $\theta = 1$ and uniform first state. Apply (2) at $T = N - 1$ with counts $(s - 1, N - s)$, where $Q_{N-1} = 1/N$, then sum over the last state.

(b) We write the ratio as a sum over paths. Only the path with every step $+1$ has $A_N = N$, and it never switches. So $\mathbb{P}_+(A_N = N)$ is the first product in (1), and dividing by it leaves

$$\frac{\mathbb{P}_+(A_N = s)}{\mathbb{P}_+(A_N = N)} = \sum_x \prod_{t:\, x_t \ne x_{t-1}} \omega_t, \tag{4}$$

where the sum is over the paths $x$ with $x_1 = +1$ and $s$ steps equal to $+1$. For example, for $N = 3$ and $s = 2$ the paths are $(+, +, -)$ and $(+, -, +)$, and the ratio is $\omega_3 + \omega_2\omega_3$. For $1 \le s \le N - 1$ there is such a path, and each of them switches at least once. So the right side is a sum of products of the $\omega_t$ with at least one factor each. Each $\omega_t$ is positive and increases strictly in $c$, so the sum does too. By (a) it equals 1 at $c = 1$. □

After a shift of one step, part (a) is the exercise in [29, Section 3.1, footnote 1]. That footnote also says that the fact can be related to Pólya urns (the authors credit M. Balázs) and that a more general connection of their model with Pólya urns will appear in a later paper. That connection is developed in Chapter 7 of the dated draft, and after the same shift part (a), with the last state, is (author draft, Claim 7.1). So part (a) is not new. What we add for two states is part (b), and the count law also follows from [24, Theorem 2.18] (Section 3.1). Both parts of Proposition 3.3 are also proved in Lean (Section 4).

### 3.3 $d$ states

The same thing happens for a chain on $d$ states that leaves its current state for each other state at the same aging rate. Fix $d \geq 2$ and $\theta$ with $0 < \theta < d/(d-1)$. The chain $X_1, X_2, \ldots$ on $\{1, \ldots, d\}$ starts at $X_1 = 1$. At step $k \geq 2$ it moves to each of the other $d-1$ states with probability $\theta/(k+d-2)$, and it stays with probability $1-(d-1)\theta/(k+d-2)$. The condition on $\theta$ says that the probability of staying is positive at every step $k \geq 2$. Let $L_N = (L_N(1), \ldots, L_N(d))$ be the vector of visit counts, namely $L_N(i) = \#\{k \leq N : X_k = i\}$. Its values are the compositions $n = (n_1, \ldots, n_d)$ of $N$ into $d$ nonnegative parts with $n_1 \geq 1$. There are $\binom{N+d-2}{d-1}$ of them (subtract one from $n_1$). We call them bins. The corner $Ne_1$, where $e_i$ is the $i$-th unit vector, is the bin of the chain that never moves.

For such chains Dietz and Sethuraman [20, Theorem 1.4] proved that the fractions of time converge in law to the Dirichlet law with every parameter $\theta$, which is uniform on the simplex exactly at $\theta = 1$. After a shift of the time index by $d-2$, their chain and ours have the same transition probabilities at every time $n \geq d+1$, and after one common fresh draw the two chains agree, so their fractions of time have the same limit. At $\theta = 1$, part (a) of the theorem below is an exact finite-$N$ form of this limit.

**Theorem 3.4** ($d$ states)**.** *Let $d \geq 2$, $0 < \theta < d/(d-1)$ and $N \geq 2$.*

*(a) At $\theta = 1$, for every bin $n$ and every state $j$,*

$$\mathbb{P}(L_N = n,\, X_N = j) = \frac{n_j - \mathbf{1}\{j = 1\}}{(N-1)\binom{N+d-2}{d-1}}. \tag{5}$$

*So $L_N$ is uniform on the $\binom{N+d-2}{d-1}$ bins, the corner included.*

*(b) For every bin $n \neq Ne_1$ the ratio $\mathbb{P}(L_N = n)/\mathbb{P}(L_N = Ne_1)$ increases strictly in $\theta$, and it equals 1 exactly at $\theta = 1$.*

In words, at $\theta = 1$, given the counts, the last state is distributed as the state at a uniformly chosen one of the steps $2, \ldots, N$ (the forced first visit to state 1 is left out). Below $\theta = 1$ the corner is the most likely bin, and above it the corner is the least likely.

*Proof.* (a) At $\theta = 1$, $X_2$ is uniform and $Y_t = X_{t+1}$ is the chain of Proposition 3.1. Its count vector is $L_N - e_1$, and $Q_{N-1} = 1/\binom{N+d-2}{d-1}$. Formula (2) gives (5), and summing over $j$ gives the uniform law.

(b) A path $x \in \{1, \ldots, d\}^N$ with $x_1 = 1$ has probability $\prod_{k=2}^{N}\bigl(1 - \frac{(d-1)\theta}{k+d-2}\bigr)$ times the product of the odds

$$\omega_t^{(d)} = \frac{\theta/(t+d-2)}{1-(d-1)\theta/(t+d-2)} = \frac{\theta}{t+d-2-(d-1)\theta}$$

over the times $t \geq 2$ with $x_t \neq x_{t-1}$. The denominator is positive and decreases in $\theta$, so each $\omega_t^{(d)}$ increases strictly in $\theta$. Only the constant path has counts $Ne_1$. So $\mathbb{P}(L_N = n)/\mathbb{P}(L_N = Ne_1)$ is the sum of the products of the odds over the paths with counts $n$. For a bin $n \neq Ne_1$ there is such a path, and each of them moves at least once. Hence the ratio increases strictly in $\theta$, and by (a) it equals 1 at $\theta = 1$. □

*Remark* 3.5. For $d = 2$ the chain switches at step $k$ with probability $\theta/k$, so Theorem 3.4 with $\theta = c$ is Proposition 3.3, and (5) reads $(s-1)/(N(N-1))$ for $j = 1$ and $n = (s, N-s)$.

By Proposition 3.1, $(L_N - e_1, X_N)$ has the law of the counts and last color of $N-1$ draws from Pólya's urn with one ball of each color. This is an identity at each fixed time, not an identity of path laws. For example, with $d=2$ and $N=4$ the chain path $1,1,2,2$ has probability $1/8$, while the urn draws $1,2,2$ have probability $1/12$. For two states Engländer and Volkov call this relation mimicking (author draft, Definition 7.1 and Lemma 7.1), and they show with an example of three steps that the coin-turning walk and the urn have different path laws (author draft, Example 7.1). Also, at $\theta = 1$ the chain moves at step $k$ with probability $(d-1)/(k+d-2)$, independently over $k$. This is the probability that customer $k$ opens a new table in the Chinese restaurant process with parameter $d-1$. So the expected number of moves in $N$ steps at the tie is $\sum_{k=2}^{N} \frac{d-1}{k+d-2} = (d-1)\log N + O(1)$, which has the same order, $\log N$, as the number of turns at the crossing from the corners to the center for $d$ directions and runs of geometric length [3].

We checked (5), and the strict ordering in (b) along the five values $\theta = \frac{1}{2}, \frac{9}{10}, 1, \frac{11}{10}, \frac{5}{4}$, in exact rational arithmetic for $d = 2,3,4$ and $2 \le N \le 8$ (`verify_aging.py`).

### 3.4 A fair first step

We return to two states and let the first step be fair. Then both ends can be reached, and $E_N = \mathbb{P}(A_N = N) = \frac{1}{2}\prod_{k=2}^{N}(1 - c/k)$. Changing the sign of every step preserves the law of the walk and sends $A_N$ to $N - A_N$. So

$$\mathbb{P}(A_N = s) = \tfrac{1}{2}\big(\mathbb{P}_+(A_N = s) + \mathbb{P}_+(A_N = N - s)\big), \qquad E_N = \tfrac{1}{2}\mathbb{P}_+(A_N = N), \tag{6}$$

since $\mathbb{P}_+(A_N = 0) = 0$.

**Proposition 3.6** (fair first step)**.** *Let $N \ge 2$ and $1 \le s \le N-1$, with a fair first step.*

*(a) At $c = 1$, $\mathbb{P}(A_N = s) = \frac{1}{N}$ and $E_N = \frac{1}{2N}$.*

*(b) The ratio $\mathbb{P}(A_N = s)/E_N$ is continuous and strictly increasing in $c \in (0,2)$. It tends to 0 as $c \downarrow 0$ and equals 2 at $c = 1$. So there is exactly one $c$ in $(0,2)$ with $\mathbb{P}(A_N = s) = E_N$, and it is less than 1.*

For even $N$ we write $c_N$ for the crossing in (b) with $s = h = N/2$, so that $C_N = E_N$ exactly at $c = c_N$. In words, at $c = 1$ every interior bin still has probability $\frac{1}{N}$, and the two ends share the probability $\frac{1}{N}$ that the fixed start gave to one end. Related fair-start formulas for switch probabilities $1/(n+a)$ appear in (author draft, Section 5.7, p. 76). Its first displayed family is twice a normalized law. We do not use that formula, and derive (a) from the averaging identity (6).

*Proof.* (a) This follows from (6) and Proposition 3.3(a). (b) By (6) the ratio is the sum of the right sides of (4) for $s$ and for $N - s$. Both are finite sums of products of at least one $\omega_t$. So the ratio is continuous and strictly increasing, and it tends to 0 as $c \downarrow 0$. By (a) it equals 2 at $c = 1$. Hence it equals 1 exactly once, at some $c < 1$. □

How far below 1 is $c_N$? The end is of order $N^{-c}$ and the center is of order $1/N$, so they meet when $N^{1-c}$ is about 2.

**Proposition 3.7** (the fair-start crossing)**.** *For even $N \to \infty$,*

$$c_N = 1 - \frac{\log 2}{\log N + \gamma + 2 - 2\log 2} + O\big((\log N)^{-3}\big),$$

*where $\gamma$ is Euler's constant.*

**Idea of the proof.** A monotonicity argument first traps $c_N$ within $O(1/\log N)$ of 1, so an expansion at $c = 1$ applies. The end is explicit, namely $E_N = \Gamma(N+1-c)/(2\Gamma(2-c)\Gamma(N+1))$, which is $N^{-c}/(2\Gamma(2-c))$ with relative error $O(1/N)$. For the center we prove a local limit theorem with a rate, namely $NC_N = d_c + O(\sqrt{\log N/N})$ uniformly for $c \in [c^{(3)}, 1]$, where $c^{(3)} = (9-\sqrt{57})/2 \approx 0.725$ and $d_c = 4^{1-c}/\mathrm{B}(c,c)$ is the density of $\mathrm{Beta}(c,c)$ at $\frac{1}{2}$. So $\log(C_N/E_N) = (c-1)\log N + \Theta(c) + O(\sqrt{\log N/N})$ with $\Theta(c) = \log(2\Gamma(2-c)d_c)$. Here $\Theta(1) = \log 2$ and $\Theta'(1) = \gamma + 2 - 2\log 2$, and solving for the zero gives the expansion. The proof is in Appendix B. There $C_N$ is an average of explicit numbers over the law of the time of the $h$-th step $+1$ (Lemma B.1). The local limit theorem comes from a coupling of the walk with the chain of Proposition 3.1 with $d = 2$ and $\theta = c$, whose counts are a mixture of binomial laws with a $\mathrm{Beta}(c,c)$ parameter (Proposition B.3).

The error term decays only like $(\log N)^{-3}$, but the expansion is already accurate at moderate $N$. The computed crossing at $N = 200$ is $c_{200} = 0.8925$, against 0.8932 from the expansion without its error term. The constant in the error term is not computed.

# 4 Verification

This section says how the numbers in this paper were computed and which results are also proved in Lean. All computations are in Python. The values of $R_N$ in Table 1 were computed in two ways, both from Proposition 2.2, namely by its formula and by a spectral method that reads each factor off as a Taylor coefficient of a generating function. For small $N$ they were also checked against a recursion on the first run and a sum over all run compositions, which do not use Proposition 2.2. The aging probabilities, and with them the crossing $c_{200}$, were computed in three ways, namely by a forward recursion, from transfer matrices at roots of unity, and from the sums over paths in (4). In exact rational arithmetic $C_{200} - E_{200}$ is negative at $c_{200} - 10^{-6}$ and positive at $c_{200} + 10^{-6}$.

No proof in this paper rests on a computation. The tables, the figures and the numbers quoted outside the proofs rest on computation alone. The script `verify_heavy_runs.py` recomputes the numbers of Section 2 and Appendix A, the script `verify_aging.py` those of Section 3 and Appendix B, and `verify_aging_urn.py` checks Proposition 3.1 in exact arithmetic for two, three and four states. The numbers in the caption of Figure 2 come from `figures/make_aging_figure.py`.

Many statements of this paper are also proved in Lean 4.33.1 with Mathlib at commit `0df444a360ea`, in the folder `kagey-problems/problem131/lean/PaperD`, which is shared with an earlier version of this work. The file `MAP.md` there lists each statement of this paper by its label, with its Lean names, its status in Lean and the source of each classical input. The kernel checks every proof, and every theorem depends only on the axioms `propext`, `Classical.choice` and `Quot.sound`. The statement-by-label table in `MAP.md` and the detailed table `coverage_F.tex` record the coverage and its qualifications. Some proofs use six classical results, which Lean states as named hypotheses, and nothing else is assumed. These are the local limit theorem of Gnedenko (GN) [14, Theorem 4.2.1], the expansion of $\mathrm{Li}_s(e^{-v})$ near $v = 0$ (POLY) [19, 25.12.12], the continuity theorem of Lévy (LEVY) and Fourier inversion for an integrable characteristic function (FI) [17, Section XV.3], the continuity theorem for Laplace transforms (LAP) [17, Section XIII.1] and the uniqueness theorem of Lerch for Laplace transforms (LERCH) [39, Chapter II].

One proof in Lean differs from ours. In Step 4 of the proof of Theorem 2.8, Lean finds $\int_0^\infty tg(t)^2\,dt$ from $\mathbb{E}G^{i\tau}$ by Parseval's identity for the density of $\log G$, so it does not identify the law of $G_1/(G_1+G_2)$. Lean does not formalize the six classical results, Theorem 2.7, Remarks 2.6, 3.2 and 2.9, or the numbers that rest on computation.

**Open questions.** For the heavy-tailed walk, a rate in Theorem 2.4 remains open. So does monotonicity of $E_N/C_N$ in $N$, which would give uniqueness of a crossover size when the two probabilities exchange order.

**Acknowledgments.** I thank Peter Kagey for posing the problem and Aidan Deshong for insightful conversations.

## A note on the use of AI

I wrote the original draft and its mathematics. I used Claude Opus 5.5 (Anthropic) for revision and proof checking, and later used OpenAI Codex to shorten the exposition and check references. The latter revision includes the title, the derivations from the urn law and the verification discussion. AI tools generated the Lean files and parts of the verification code, which I reviewed against the paper. Section 4 states what Lean proves and which classical results it takes as hypotheses. I checked the revisions and take responsibility for the contents of the paper.

## A Proofs for Section 2

Sections A.1 to A.4 treat $\alpha > 1$ and prove Theorems 2.4 and 2.7 together. Section A.5 treats $0 < \alpha < 1$ and proves Theorem 2.8.

We use the notation of Section 2, with $\tau_0 = 0$. For a first run $D$ let $\tau_m^D = D + \tau'_{m-1}$, where $(\tau'_m)$ is an independent copy of $(\tau_m)$, and $\tau_0^D = 0$. Then $u_m^D(k) = \mathbb{P}(\tau_m^D = k)$ and $q_m^D(k) = \mathbb{P}(\tau_{m-1}^D < k \le \tau_m^D)$. We find each of these by conditioning on where the run before ends. For example, the $m$-th run covers level $k$ exactly when the first $m-1$ runs end at some level $k-j$ with $j \ge 1$ and the $m$-th run has length at least $j$. In this way, for $m, k \ge 1$,

$$q_m(k) = \sum_{j\ge1} \bar{F}(j)\, u_{m-1}(k-j), \qquad q_{m+1}^D(k) = \sum_{j\ge1} \bar{F}(j)\, u_m^D(k-j),$$
$$u_m^D(k) = \sum_{\ell\ge1} \mathbb{P}(D=\ell)\, u_{m-1}(k-\ell). \tag{7}$$

Here $u_0(k) = \mathbf{1}\{k=0\}$. The sums $\tau_m$ and $\tau_m^D$ increase strictly in $m$. So exactly one run covers a given level $k \ge 1$, and at most one run ends there. Hence $\sum_m q_m(k) = \sum_m q_m^D(k) = 1$ and $\sum_m u_m(k) \le 1$, $\sum_m u_m^D(k) \le 1$. Also, the first $m'$ runs reach level $k$ exactly when one of them covers it, so $\sum_{m\le m'} q_m(k) = \mathbb{P}(\tau_{m'} \ge k)$, and in the same way $\sum_{m\le m'} q_m^D(k) = \mathbb{P}(\tau_{m'}^D \ge k)$.

### A.1 The setting for $\alpha > 1$

Let $\alpha > 1$, so that $\mu = \zeta(\alpha) < \infty$. The proof of the center asymptotics uses the exponent only through the following three facts about a norming sequence $(a_m)$ of positive numbers.

(F1) For $m \ge 3$ we have $a_m = a(m)$, where $a(x) = c_a x^\kappa (\log x)^\beta$ on $[3,\infty)$ with constants $c_a > 0$, $0 < \kappa < 1$ and $\beta \ge 0$.

(F2) The variables $(\tau_m - m\mu)/a_m$ converge in law to a variable $G$ that has a bounded, uniformly continuous density $g$ with $g(z) \to 0$ as $|z| \to \infty$. With $z_{m,k} = (k - m\mu)/a_m$, the numbers $\delta_m = \sup_k |a_m u_m(k) - g(z_{m,k})|$ tend to 0, and $\bar{u} = \sup_{m\ge1} \sup_k a_m u_m(k)$ is finite.

(F3) There is a constant $C_B$ such that $u_m(k) \le C_B\, m\, k^{-\alpha-1}$ for all $m \ge 1$ and $k \ge 2m\mu$.

The function $a$ in (F1) is increasing, and $a(\lambda x)/a(x) \to \lambda^\kappa$ as $x \to \infty$, uniformly for $\lambda$ in a compact subset of $(0,\infty)$. So $a_m \to \infty$ and $a_m/a_{m-1} \to 1$. For $1 < \alpha < 2$ we take $a_m = m^{1/\alpha}$. Then (F1) holds with $\kappa = 1/\alpha$ and $\beta = 0$, (F2) is Lemma 2.3(ii) and (iii), and (F3) is Lemma A.1 below. We write $\omega$ for the modulus of continuity of $g$ and $\bar g(x) = \sup_{|y|\ge x} g(y)$. So $\omega(\eta) \to 0$ as $\eta \to 0$ and $\bar g(x) \to 0$ as $x \to \infty$.

## A.2 Two lemmas on renewal sums

A sum of $m$ runs that is much larger than its mean is most likely made by a single long run. The first lemma turns this into a local bound. Bounds of this kind are classical in the big-jump domain [16]. We include a short proof to keep the paper self-contained.

**Lemma A.1.** *Let $\alpha > 1$. There is a constant $C_B = C_B(\alpha)$ such that $u_m(k) \le C_B\, m\, k^{-\alpha-1}$ for all $m \ge 1$ and $k \ge 2m\mu$.*

*Proof.* We split the event $\{\tau_m = k\}$ according to whether some run is long, namely at least $y = k/r$, where $r > 2$ is a constant that depends only on $\alpha$ and is chosen below. The first part is small because one run takes a given value $\ell \ge y$ with probability at most $\alpha y^{-\alpha-1}$. If no run is long, then $\tau_m$ is a sum of variables below $y$ whose mean is at most $k/2$, and a Chernoff bound shows that such a sum rarely reaches $k$. Here $C$ depends only on $\alpha$ and may change from line to line. Since $\mu \ge 1$ we have $m \le k/2$.

*One big jump.* By the mean value theorem $\mathbb{P}(\xi = \ell) = \ell^{-\alpha} - (\ell+1)^{-\alpha} \le \alpha \ell^{-\alpha-1}$. Fix an index $i$. Then

$$\mathbb{P}(\tau_m = k,\, \xi_i \ge y) = \sum_{\ell \ge y} \mathbb{P}(\xi = \ell)\, \mathbb{P}(\tau_m - \xi_i = k - \ell) \le \alpha y^{-\alpha-1} = \alpha r^{\alpha+1} k^{-\alpha-1},$$

because the first factor is at most $\alpha y^{-\alpha-1}$ and the second factors add up to at most 1. The $m$ indices together give at most $\alpha r^{\alpha+1} m k^{-\alpha-1}$.

*No big jump.* We may take $y \ge 1$, since otherwise $\max_i \xi_i < y$ is impossible. Let $x_0 > 0$ and $s \ge 0$. For $0 \le x \le s$ we have $e^x \le 1 + x + \frac{x^2}{2} e^s$. We use this with $x = s\xi/y$ on the event $\{\xi < y\}$ and then $1 + x \le e^x$. This gives $\mathbb{E}[e^{s\xi/y}; \xi < y] \le \exp\bigl(\frac{s}{y}\mathbb{E}[\xi; \xi < y] + \frac{s^2 e^s}{2y^2}\mathbb{E}[\xi^2; \xi < y]\bigr)$. By independence and Markov's inequality for $e^{s\tau_m/y}$,

$$\mathbb{P}\bigl(\tau_m \ge x_0,\ \max_{i \le m} \xi_i < y\bigr) \le \exp\Bigl(-\frac{s x_0}{y} + m\Bigl(\frac{s}{y}\,\mathbb{E}[\xi; \xi < y] + \frac{s^2 e^s}{2y^2}\,\mathbb{E}[\xi^2; \xi < y]\Bigr)\Bigr). \tag{8}$$

We take $x_0 = k$. Since $\mathbb{E}[\xi; \xi < y] \le \mu$ and $k - m\mu \ge k/2$, the first two terms of the exponent add up to at most $-\frac{s}{y} \cdot \frac{k}{2} = -sr/2$. So the exponent is at most $-sr/2 + \frac{1}{2} r^2 s^2 e^s\, m\, k^{-2}\, \mathbb{E}[\xi^2; \xi < y]$. It remains to choose $s$ and $r$ so that the bound is at most $Cmk^{-\alpha-1}$. The choice depends on how fast the truncated second moment grows, so there are three cases.

Let $1 < \alpha < 2$. Then $\mathbb{E}[\xi^2; \xi < y] \le \alpha \sum_{\ell < y} \ell^{1-\alpha} \le C y^{2-\alpha}$, so the exponent is at most $-sr/2 + Cr^\alpha s^2 e^s m/k^\alpha$. Take $s = \frac{1}{2}\log(k^\alpha/m)$, which is positive since $m \le k/2 < k^\alpha$. Then $e^s m/k^\alpha = e^{-s}$ and $s^2 e^{-s} \le 1$, so the second term is at most $Cr^\alpha$. The first term is $-\frac{r}{4}\log(k^\alpha/m)$. So the probability is at most $C(m/k^\alpha)^{r/4}$. We take $r = 4 + 4/(\alpha - 1)$, so that $r/4 = 1 + 1/(\alpha - 1)$. Since $m \le k$, the bound is at most $C(m/k^\alpha)(k^{1-\alpha})^{1/(\alpha-1)} = Cmk^{-\alpha-1}$.

Let $\alpha > 2$. Then $\mathbb{E}[\xi^2; \xi < y] \le \mathbb{E}\xi^2 < \infty$, so the exponent is at most $-sr/2 + Cr^2 s^2 e^s m/k^2$. Take $s = \frac{1}{2}\log(k^2/m)$, which is positive since $m < k^2$. As before the probability is at most $C(m/k^2)^{r/4}$. With $r = 4\alpha$ and $m \le k$ this is $C\,m\,m^{\alpha-1}k^{-2\alpha} \le Cmk^{-\alpha-1}$.

Let $\alpha = 2$. Then $\mathbb{E}[\xi^2; \xi < y] \le 2\sum_{\ell<y} \ell^{-1} \le 2\log(ek)$, so the exponent is at most $-sr/2 + r^2 s^2 e^s m \log(ek)/k^2$. Take $s = \frac{1}{2}\log\frac{k^2}{m\log(ek)}$, which is positive since $m\log(ek) \le \frac{1}{2}k\log(ek) < k^2$. As before the probability is at most $C(m\log(ek)/k^2)^{r/4}$. With $r = 20$ and $m \le k$ this is at most $Cmk^{-6}\log^5(ek) \le Cmk^{-3}$.

In each case the two bounds together give the lemma. □

**Lemma A.2.** *Let $\alpha > 1$ and assume* (F1) *and* (F2). *Let $D$ be any a.s. finite first run. Then*

$$\sup_k \Big|\frac{a_m}{\mu} q_m(k) - g(z_{m,k})\Big|, \qquad \sup_k \big|a_m u_m^D(k) - g(z_{m,k})\big|, \qquad \sup_k \Big|\frac{a_m}{\mu} q_{m+1}^D(k) - g(z_{m,k})\Big|$$

*tend to 0 as $m \to \infty$. For $m \ge 2$, $\sup_k q_m(k) \le \mu\bar{u}/a_{m-1}$ and $\sup_k u_m^D(k) \le \bar{u}/a_{m-1}$.*

*Proof.* By (7), $q_m$ and $u_m^D$ are sums of shifts of $u_{m-1}$ with total weights $\sum_j \bar{F}(j) = \mu$ and 1. Since $u_{m-1}(k) \le \bar{u}/a_{m-1}$, this gives the two bounds for $m \ge 2$.

For the limits we use that a shift by a bounded amount $j$ moves the point $z_{m,k}$ only by $O(1/a_m)$, and that $g$ is uniformly continuous. So the local limit for $u_{m-1}$ passes to these sums. We give the details for $q_m$. Fix $J \ge 1$ and $Z > 0$, put $\sigma_J = \sum_{j>J} \bar{F}(j)$ and write $z = z_{m,k}$. We compare term by term the two sums

$$a_{m-1}q_m(k) = \sum_{j\ge 1} \bar{F}(j)\, a_{m-1}u_{m-1}(k-j) \qquad \text{and} \qquad \mu g(z) = \sum_{j\ge 1} \bar{F}(j)\, g(z).$$

The terms with $j > J$ add up to at most $\bar{u}\sigma_J$ in the first sum and $\|g\|_\infty \sigma_J$ in the second.

Let $j \le J$. By (F2), $|a_{m-1}u_{m-1}(k-j) - g(z_{m-1,k-j})| \le \delta_{m-1}$. Next we compare $g(z_{m-1,k-j})$ with $g(z)$. The definition of $z_{m,k}$ gives $z_{m-1,k-j} = z\,a_m/a_{m-1} + (\mu - j)/a_{m-1}$. If $|z| \le Z$, then $|z_{m-1,k-j} - z| \le \eta_m$ with $\eta_m = Z|a_m/a_{m-1} - 1| + (J+\mu)/a_{m-1}$, so the two values of $g$ differ by at most $\omega(\eta_m)$. If $|z| > Z$, then $|z_{m-1,k-j}| \ge Z/2$ once $m$ is large (how large depends only on $J$ and $Z$), so both values lie in $[0, \bar{g}(Z/2)]$. In both cases they differ by at most $\omega(\eta_m) + \bar{g}(Z/2)$. Hence, uniformly in $k$ for large $m$,

$$\big|a_{m-1}q_m(k) - \mu g(z)\big| \le \mu\big(\delta_{m-1} + \omega(\eta_m) + \bar{g}(Z/2)\big) + (\bar{u} + \|g\|_\infty)\sigma_J.$$

Here $\eta_m \to 0$ as $m \to \infty$. So we let $m \to \infty$ and then $J, Z \to \infty$, and the right side tends to 0. Since $a_m/a_{m-1} \to 1$ and $a_{m-1}q_m(k) \le \mu\bar{u}$, we may replace $a_{m-1}$ by $a_m$ on the left. This gives the first limit.

The second limit follows in the same way from the sum for $u_m^D$, with the weights $\mathbb{P}(D = \ell)$ and with $\mathbb{P}(D > J)$ in place of $\sigma_J$, which tends to 0 as $J \to \infty$ because $D$ is a.s. finite. The third follows from the sum for $q_{m+1}^D$, with $a_m u_m^D$ in place of $a_{m-1}u_{m-1}$, the second limit in place of $\delta_{m-1} \to 0$, and the shift $z_{m,k-j} - z_{m,k} = -j/a_m$. For the terms with $j > J$ we use the bound $a_m u_m^D(k) \le \bar{u}\,a_m/a_{m-1}$ from above in place of $\bar{u}$, and $a_m/a_{m-1}$ is bounded since it tends to 1. □

## A.3 The center for $\alpha > 1$

**Proposition A.3.** *Let $\alpha > 1$ and assume* (F1), (F2) *and* (F3). *Let $D$ be any a.s. finite first run and put $b_h = a(h/\mu)$. As $N = 2h \to \infty$,*

$$C_N \sim \frac{2}{b_h}\int_{\mathbb{R}} g(z)^2\, dz.$$

**Idea of the proof.** We split the sum in Proposition 2.2 by the number $m$ of runs into four regions. In the main region $|m\mu - h| \le Mb_h$ both factors are given by the local limit theorem, and the terms form a Riemann sum for $2b_h^{-1}\int_{-M}^{M} g^2$. For $m \le h/(4\mu)$ the level $h$ is far above the mean of $\tau_m$, and (F3) makes these terms $O(h^{-\alpha})$. In the other two regions (the $m$ between these two, and the $m$ above the main region) one factor of each term is $O(1/b_h)$, and the other factors add up to a tail probability of $G$, which is small when $M$ is large.

*Proof.* By Proposition 2.2, $C_N = \sum_{m\ge1}\big[u_m(h)q^D_{m+1}(h) + u^D_m(h)q_m(h)\big]$. Fix $M > 1$, put $m_\pm = (h \pm Mb_h)/\mu$, and let $\Sigma_1, \dots, \Sigma_4$ be the parts of this sum over the regions $\mathcal{R}_1 = \{m \le h/(4\mu)\}$, $\mathcal{R}_2 = \{h/(4\mu) < m < m_-\}$, $\mathcal{R}_3 = \{m_- \le m \le m_+\}$ and $\mathcal{R}_4 = \{m > m_+\}$. We show that $b_h\Sigma_3$ tends to $2\int_{-M}^{M} g^2$ and that the other three parts are small.

We need three consequences of (F1). First, $b_h = o(h)$ and $h^{-\alpha} = o(1/b_h)$, since $\kappa < 1 < \alpha$. Second, $a(h/(8\mu)) \ge b_h/9$ and $a(h/(2\mu)) \ge b_h/3$ for large $h$, since $8^{-\kappa} > \frac19$ and $2^{-\kappa} > \frac13$. Third, $a_m/b_h \to 1$ uniformly in $m$ with $|m\mu - h| \le 2Mb_h$.

*Region $\mathcal{R}_1$ (far too few runs).* Here $h \ge 4m\mu$, so level $h$ is far above the mean of $\tau_m$. We show that $u_m(h)$ and $q_m(h)$ are both $O(h^{-\alpha})$ for $m \in \mathcal{R}_1$. By (F3), $u_m(h) \le C_B m h^{-\alpha-1} \le C_B h^{-\alpha}/(4\mu)$. Also $q_1(h) = h^{-\alpha}$. For $m \ge 2$ we split the sum for $q_m(h)$ in (7) at $j = h/2$. The terms with $j \ge h/2$ have $\bar F(j) \le (h/2)^{-\alpha}$, and the factors $u_{m-1}(h-j)$ add up to at most 1. So these terms add up to at most $(h/2)^{-\alpha}$. For $j < h/2$ we have $h - j > h/2 \ge 2\mu(m-1)$, so (F3) applies to $u_{m-1}(h-j)$, and the weights $\bar F(j)$ add up to at most $\mu$. So the other terms add up to at most $\mu C_B(m-1)(h/2)^{-\alpha-1} \le 2^{\alpha-1}C_B h^{-\alpha}$. In $\Sigma_1$ each of these factors is multiplied by $q^D_{m+1}(h)$ or by $u^D_m(h)$, and $\sum_m q^D_{m+1}(h) \le 1$ and $\sum_m u^D_m(h) \le 1$. Hence $\Sigma_1 = O(h^{-\alpha})$, which is $o(1/b_h)$.

*Region $\mathcal{R}_2$ (too few runs).* In each term one factor is at most $9\bar u/b_h$, and the other factors add up to the probability that few runs reach level $h$. For large $h$ we have $m - 1 \ge h/(8\mu)$ here, so $a_m \ge a_{m-1} \ge b_h/9$ and $u_m(h), u^D_m(h) \le 9\bar u/b_h$ by (F2) and Lemma A.2. Let $m' = \lfloor m_-\rfloor$. Every $m \in \mathcal{R}_2$ is at most $m'$, so $\sum_{m\in\mathcal{R}_2} q_m(h) \le \mathbb{P}(\tau_{m'} \ge h)$ and $\sum_{m\in\mathcal{R}_2} q^D_{m+1}(h) \le \mathbb{P}(D + \tau'_{m'} \ge h)$. The last probability is at most $\mathbb{P}(D \ge b_h) + \mathbb{P}(\tau_{m'} \ge h - b_h)$. Since $m'\mu \le h - Mb_h$ and $a_{m'} \le b_h$, the event $\{\tau_{m'} \ge h - b_h\}$ implies $(\tau_{m'} - m'\mu)/a_{m'} \ge M - 1$. Now $\mathbb{P}(D \ge b_h) \to 0$ because $D$ is a.s. finite, and $(\tau_{m'} - m'\mu)/a_{m'}$ converges in law to $G$, which has a continuous law. So $\limsup_h b_h\Sigma_2 \le 18\bar u\,\mathbb{P}(G \ge M - 1)$.

*Region $\mathcal{R}_4$ (too many runs).* This is like $\mathcal{R}_2$. For large $h$ we have $m - 1 \ge h/(2\mu)$ here, so $u_m(h), u^D_m(h) \le 3\bar u/b_h$. Let $m'' = \lfloor m_+\rfloor$. The runs after the first $m''$ cover level $h$ exactly when the first $m''$ do not reach it. So $\sum_{m\in\mathcal{R}_4} q_m(h) = \mathbb{P}(\tau_{m''} < h)$ and, since $D \ge 1$, $\sum_{m\in\mathcal{R}_4} q^D_{m+1}(h) = \mathbb{P}(D + \tau'_{m''} < h) \le \mathbb{P}(\tau_{m''} < h)$. Now $m''\mu > h + Mb_h - \mu$, so $(h - m''\mu)/a_{m''} \le (\mu - Mb_h)/a_{m''} \to -M$. Hence $\limsup_h b_h\Sigma_4 \le 6\bar u\,\mathbb{P}(G \le -M)$.

*Region $\mathcal{R}_3$ (the main part).* Here $m \to \infty$ and $a_m = b_h(1 + o(1))$ uniformly. By (F2) and Lemma A.2, the factors $u_m(h)$ and $u^D_m(h)$ are $(g(z_{m,h}) + o(1))/a_m$, and the factors $q_m(h)$ and $q^D_{m+1}(h)$ are $\mu(g(z_{m,h}) + o(1))/a_m$. So, uniformly in $m \in \mathcal{R}_3$,

$$u_m(h)q^D_{m+1}(h) + u^D_m(h)q_m(h) = \frac{2\mu}{a_m^2}\big(g(z_{m,h})^2 + o(1)\big).$$

Put $y_m = (h - m\mu)/b_h$. Then $z_{m,h} = y_m b_h/a_m$ and $|y_m| \le M$, so $|z_{m,h} - y_m| \le M|b_h/a_m - 1| \to 0$ and $g(z_{m,h})^2 = g(y_m)^2 + o(1)$. The $y_m$ with $m \in \mathcal{R}_3$ are the points of an arithmetic progression with step $\mu/b_h$ that lie in $[-M, M]$. There are at most $2Mb_h/\mu + 1$ of them, so the $o(1)$ terms below add up to $o(1)$, and the rest is a Riemann sum. Hence

$$b_h\Sigma_3 = 2\big(1 + o(1)\big)\frac{\mu}{b_h}\sum_{m\in\mathcal{R}_3}\big(g(y_m)^2 + o(1)\big) \to 2\int_{-M}^{M} g^2.$$

Adding the four regions,

$$\limsup_{h\to\infty}\Big|b_hC_N - 2\int g^2\Big| \le 2\int_{|z|>M} g^2 + 18\bar{u}\,\mathbb{P}(G \ge M-1) + 6\bar{u}\,\mathbb{P}(G \le -M),$$

and letting $M \to \infty$ gives $C_N \sim 2b_h^{-1}\int g^2$. □

*Proof of Theorem 2.4.* Let $1 < \alpha < 2$ and $a_m = m^{1/\alpha}$. As noted in Section A.1, (F1) to (F3) hold, with $b_h = (h/\mu)^{1/\alpha}$. So Proposition A.3 gives $C_N \sim 2I_\alpha(\mu/h)^{1/\alpha}$, and the second form follows from Lemma 2.3(iv) and $h = N/2$. □

### A.4 Proof of Theorem 2.7

We apply Proposition A.3 with the standard normal density in place of the stable density. So let $\alpha \ge 2$ and let $g$ be the standard normal density. We have to find a norming sequence $(a_m)$ with (F1), (F2) and (F3). Fact (F3) is Lemma A.1, which holds for every $\alpha > 1$. For (F2) it is enough that $(\tau_m - m\mu)/a_m$ converges in law to the standard normal law. Indeed, $g$ is bounded and uniformly continuous and vanishes at $\pm\infty$. Every $\mathbb{P}(\xi = k)$ is positive, so $\xi$ has maximal span 1, and Gnedenko's local limit theorem [14, Theorem 4.2.1] turns the convergence in law into $\delta_m \to 0$. Then $\bar{u} < \infty$ follows as in the proof of Lemma 2.3(iii). So in each of the two cases we choose $(a_m)$, check (F1) and the normal limit, and read off $b_h = a(h/\mu)$. Since $\int g^2 = 1/(2\sqrt{\pi})$, Proposition A.3 then gives $C_N \sim 1/(\sqrt{\pi}\,b_h)$.

(a) Let $\alpha > 2$. Then $\xi$ has a finite variance, and we use the central limit theorem. Summation by parts gives $\mathbb{E}\xi^2 = \sum_{k\ge1}(2k-1)\bar{F}(k) = 2\zeta(\alpha-1) - \zeta(\alpha)$, so $v = \mathbb{E}\xi^2 - \mu^2$ is as stated and finite. It is positive because $\xi$ is not constant. We take $a_m = \sqrt{vm}$. This has (F1) with $\kappa = \frac12$ and $\beta = 0$, and the central limit theorem gives the normal limit. So $b_h = \sqrt{vh/\mu}$, and with $h = N/2$ we get $C_N \sim (\pi vh/\mu)^{-1/2} = \sqrt{2\mu/(\pi vN)}$. For the stationary start Proposition 2.1 gives $E_N = N^{1-\alpha}(1 + O(1/N))/(2(\alpha-1)\mu)$. Dividing $E_N$ by $C_N$ gives $R_N \sim C_2(\alpha)N^{3/2-\alpha}$.

(b) Let $\alpha = 2$, so that $\mu = \zeta(2)$ and $\mathbb{E}\xi^2 = \infty$. The central limit theorem with the norming $\sqrt{m}$ fails, but the variance is infinite only by a logarithm, and the limit is still normal with a slightly larger norming. To see this we compute the truncated second moment

$$U(x) = \mathbb{E}[\xi^2; \xi \le x] = \sum_{k\le x} k^2\big(k^{-2} - (k+1)^{-2}\big) = \sum_{k\le x}\frac{2k+1}{(k+1)^2} = 2\log x + O(1).$$

This function varies slowly. So $\xi$ is in the domain of attraction of the normal law, and $(\tau_m - m\mu)/a_m$ converges in law to the standard normal law for every sequence $(a_m)$ with $mU(a_m)/a_m^2 \to 1$ [17, Section XVII.5]. We try $a(x) = \sqrt{x\log x}$. Then $U(a(m)) = \log m + \log\log m + O(1)$ and $a(m)^2/m = \log m$, so $mU(a(m))/a(m)^2 \to 1$. We take $a_m = a(m)$ for $m \ge 3$ and $a_1 = a_2 = 1$. This has (F1) with $\kappa = \beta = \frac12$. So $b_h^2 = (h/\mu)\log(h/\mu) \sim N\log N/(2\mu)$ and $C_N \sim \sqrt{2\mu/(\pi N\log N)}$. For the stationary start $E_N = N^{-1}(1 + O(1/N))/(2\mu)$ by Proposition 2.1. Dividing gives $R_N \sim \sqrt{\pi\log N/(8\mu^3 N)}$.

Finally we take the fresh start. In both cases it has the end $E_N = \frac12 N^{-\alpha}$ by Proposition 2.1, and the center asymptotics are the same because Proposition A.3 holds for every a.s. finite first run. So $R_N$ is of order $N^{1/2-\alpha}$ for $\alpha > 2$ and of order $N^{-3/2}(\log N)^{1/2}$ for $\alpha = 2$, and it tends to 0. □

## A.5 Proof of Theorem 2.8

Let $0 < \alpha < 1$ with a fresh start, $a_m = m^{1/\alpha}$ and $z_{m,k} = k/a_m$. There is no centering now. In this section $\mu$ is not used, and constants may depend on $\alpha$.

**Lemma A.4.** *Let $0 < \alpha < 1$.*

*(i) $\tau_m/a_m$ converges in law to a positive variable $G$ with $\mathbb{E}e^{-sG} = e^{-\Gamma(1-\alpha)s^\alpha}$ for $s \ge 0$. The law of $G$ has a bounded, uniformly continuous density $g$ that vanishes on $(-\infty, 0]$ and at $+\infty$.*

*(ii) (Gnedenko) The constant $\bar{u} = \sup_{m\ge1} \sup_k a_m u_m(k)$ is finite, and $\delta_m = \sup_k |a_m u_m(k) - g(k/a_m)| \to 0$ as $m \to \infty$.*

*(iii) There is a constant $C_B$ such that $u_m(k) \le C_B\, m\, k^{-\alpha-1}$ for all $m \ge 1$ and $k \ge a_m$.*

*(iv) $g(y) \le C_B y^{-1-\alpha}$ for $y > 1$. So $\int_0^\infty t\, g(t)^2\, dt < \infty$.*

*Proof.* (i) Summation by parts gives $1 - \mathbb{E}x^\xi = (1-x)\sum_{k\ge1} \bar{F}(k)x^{k-1}$ for $0 \le x < 1$. With $x = e^{-v}$ this is $1 - \mathbb{E}e^{-v\xi} = (e^v - 1)\mathrm{Li}_\alpha(e^{-v})$, and [19, 25.12.12] gives $\mathrm{Li}_\alpha(e^{-v}) = \Gamma(1-\alpha)v^{\alpha-1} + \zeta(\alpha) + O(v)$ as $v \downarrow 0$. So $1 - \mathbb{E}e^{-v\xi} = \Gamma(1-\alpha)v^\alpha + O(v)$. As $1/\alpha > 1$, this gives $m(1 - \mathbb{E}e^{-s\xi/a_m}) \to \Gamma(1-\alpha)s^\alpha$ for each $s \ge 0$. Hence $\mathbb{E}e^{-s\tau_m/a_m} \to e^{-\Gamma(1-\alpha)s^\alpha}$, and the continuity theorem for Laplace transforms [17, Section XIII.1] gives the limit $G \ge 0$. Both sides of $\mathbb{E}e^{-sG} = e^{-\Gamma(1-\alpha)s^\alpha}$ are continuous on $\mathrm{Re}\, s \ge 0$ and analytic on $\mathrm{Re}\, s > 0$, with the principal branch on the right. So the identity holds at $s = -i\theta$, and $|\mathbb{E}e^{i\theta G}| = \exp\bigl(-\Gamma(1-\alpha)\cos(\frac{\pi\alpha}{2})|\theta|^\alpha\bigr)$ is integrable. Fourier inversion and the Riemann–Lebesgue lemma give $g$. It vanishes on $(-\infty, 0)$ because $G \ge 0$, and at 0 by continuity.

(ii) As in Lemma 2.3(iii), $\xi$ has maximal span 1, and Gnedenko's local limit theorem [14, Theorem 4.2.1] gives $\delta_m \to 0$. Then $a_m u_m(k) \le \|g\|_\infty + 1$ for large $m$ and $a_m u_m(k) \le a_m$ for the others.

(iii) We argue as in Lemma A.1, with $r = 4 + 4/\alpha$, $y = k/r$ and $t = k^\alpha/m$, which is at least 1 because $k \ge a_m$. For infinite mean, local bounds of this kind are in Doney [15]. One step is new. For $k$ of order $a_m$ the claim is $u_m(k) \le C/a_m$, which is a local bound, and a bound for the tail of $\tau_m$ cannot give it. So we cut the $m$ runs into two halves. One half must be large, which we bound as before. The other half must then take one exact value, and this gives the factor $1/a_m$.

For $m = 1$ the claim is $\mathbb{P}(\xi = k) \le \alpha k^{-\alpha-1}$. Let $m \ge 2$. The bound $\alpha r^{\alpha+1} m k^{-\alpha-1}$ for the event that some run is at least $y$ holds as before. For the other event we may take $y \ge 1$. Split the indices into $I_1 = \{1, \dots, \lfloor m/2 \rfloor\}$ and $I_2 = \{\lfloor m/2 \rfloor + 1, \dots, m\}$, and write $\tau_I = \sum_{i\in I} \xi_i$. On $\{\tau_m = k\}$ one of $\tau_{I_1}, \tau_{I_2}$ is at least $k/2$, and then the other one equals $k$ minus it. So by independence

$$\mathbb{P}\bigl(\tau_m = k,\ \max_i \xi_i < y\bigr) \le \sum_{i=1,2} \mathbb{P}\bigl(\tau_{I_i} \ge k/2,\ \max_{j\in I_i} \xi_j < y\bigr)\ \sup_\ell \mathbb{P}(\tau_{I_{3-i}} = \ell).$$

Each half has at least $\lfloor m/2 \rfloor \ge m/3$ indices, so by (ii) the supremum is at most $\bar{u}/a_{\lfloor m/2 \rfloor} \le 3^{1/\alpha}\bar{u}/a_m$. For the first factor we use (8) for the sum over $I_i$, with $x_0 = k/2$ and at most $m$ terms. Now $\mathbb{E}[\xi; \xi < y] \le \sum_{\ell<y} \bar{F}(\ell) \le Cy^{1-\alpha}$ and $\mathbb{E}[\xi^2; \xi < y] \le Cy^{2-\alpha}$, and $my^{-\alpha} = r^\alpha/t$. So the exponent in (8) is at most $-sr/2 + C(s + s^2e^s)/t$. We take $s = \frac{1}{2}\log t$. Then $e^s = \sqrt{t}$, so the second term is bounded, and the first is $-\frac{r}{4}\log t$. Hence the first factor is at most $Ct^{-r/4} = Ct^{-1-1/\alpha}$. Since $a_m = m^{1/\alpha}$, we have $t^{-1-1/\alpha}/a_m = mk^{-\alpha-1}$, which is the claim.

(iv) Fix $y > 1$ and let $k_m = \lceil y a_m \rceil$. By (iii) and $ma_m^{-\alpha} = 1$, $a_m u_m(k_m) \le C_B m a_m (ya_m)^{-\alpha-1} = C_B y^{-1-\alpha}$. By (ii) and the continuity of $g$, the left side tends to $g(y)$ as $m \to \infty$. The integral converges because $g$ is bounded and $tg(t)^2 \le C_B^2 t^{-1-2\alpha}$ for $t > 1$. □

**Idea of the proof of Theorem 2.8.** With a fresh start, Proposition 2.2 reads $C_N = \sum_{m\ge1} u_m(h)\big[q_m(h)+q_{m+1}(h)\big]$. Put $t_m = h/a_m$. Step 1 finds $q_m(h)$ on the scale where $t_m$ is of order 1, namely $mq_m(h) \approx t_m g(t_m)/\alpha$. Step 2 sums over $m$. The terms with $t_m$ very large or very small are negligible, and the others form a Riemann sum in the variable $\log m$. This gives $NC_N \to 4\int_0^\infty tg(t)^2\,dt$. Step 3 identifies this limit as the density at $\frac12$ of $Y = G_1/(G_1+G_2)$, where $G_1, G_2$ are independent copies of $G$. Step 4 finds the law of $Y$ from the moments of $G_1/G_2$, and with it the value of the limit.

*Proof of Theorem 2.8.* Fix $M > 1$.

*Step 1.* Let $g_1(t) = \int_0^t w^{-\alpha} g(t-w)\,dw$. We claim that $mq_m(h) = g_1(t_m) + o(1)$ as $h \to \infty$, uniformly in $m$ with $t_m \in [1/(2M), 2M]$, and that $g_1(t) = tg(t)/\alpha$. The reason for the first claim is that the sum for $q_m$ in (7) is the convolution of the tail $j^{-\alpha}$ with $u_{m-1}$, and on the scale $a_m$ it becomes the convolution $g_1$. The $m$ in this range tend to infinity with $h$. Since $|k/a_{m-1} - k/a_m| \le 2M(a_m/a_{m-1}-1) \to 0$ for $0 \le k \le h$, Lemma A.4(ii) for $u_{m-1}$ and the uniform continuity of $g$ give $a_m u_{m-1}(k) = g(k/a_m) + o(1)$ uniformly in $0 \le k \le h$. As $m\,j^{-\alpha} = (j/a_m)^{-\alpha}$ and $u_{m-1}(0) = 0$, the sum for $q_m$ in (7) becomes

$$mq_m(h) = \frac{1}{a_m}\sum_{j=1}^{h-1}\Big(\frac{j}{a_m}\Big)^{-\alpha}\Big(g\big(t_m - \tfrac{j}{a_m}\big) + o(1)\Big).$$

For $x > 0$ we have $\frac{1}{a_m}\sum_{j\le x a_m}(j/a_m)^{-\alpha} \le \int_0^x w^{-\alpha}dw = x^{1-\alpha}/(1-\alpha)$. With $x = t_m \le 2M$ this shows that the $o(1)$ terms add up to $o(1)$. With $x = \eta$ it shows that the terms with $j \le \eta a_m$ are $O(\eta^{1-\alpha})$, and so is $\int_0^\eta w^{-\alpha} g(t_m - w)\,dw$. The other terms form a Riemann sum with mesh $1/a_m$ of the function $w^{-\alpha}g(t-w)$, which is uniformly continuous on $\{\eta \le w \le t \le 2M\}$. Letting $\eta \to 0$ proves the first claim.

For the second claim we compare Laplace transforms. The transform of the convolution $g_1$ is the product of those of $w^{-\alpha}$ and $g$, namely $\Gamma(1-\alpha)s^{\alpha-1}e^{-\Gamma(1-\alpha)s^\alpha}$. This is $\frac{1}{\alpha}$ times $-\frac{d}{ds}e^{-\Gamma(1-\alpha)s^\alpha}$, and minus the derivative of the transform of $g$ is the transform of $tg(t)$. Both $g_1$ and $tg(t)$ are continuous on $(0,\infty)$, so $g_1(t) = tg(t)/\alpha$.

*Step 2.* We sum $u_m(h)[q_m(h)+q_{m+1}(h)]$ over $m$ in three ranges. If $t_m > M$, then $h > Ma_m$, so $m < (h/M)^\alpha$, and Lemma A.4(iii) gives $u_m(h) \le C_B m h^{-\alpha-1} \le C_B M^{-\alpha}/h$. Since $\sum_m (q_m(h)+q_{m+1}(h)) \le 2$, these $m$ contribute at most $2C_BM^{-\alpha}/h$ to $C_N$. If $t_m < 1/M$, then $u_m(h) \le \bar u/a_m < \bar u/(Mh)$, and these $m$ contribute at most $2\bar u/(Mh)$. For the remaining $m$ we have $t_{m+1} = t_m(1+o(1)) \in [1/(2M), 2M]$ and $(m+1)/m \to 1$, and $g_1$ is uniformly continuous on $[1/(2M), 2M]$. So Step 1 applies to $q_m(h)$ and to $q_{m+1}(h)$, and both are $(t_m g(t_m)/\alpha + o(1))/m$. With $1/a_m = t_m/h$ and $\delta_m \to 0$ we get, uniformly,

$$u_m(h)\big[q_m(h)+q_{m+1}(h)\big] = \frac{t_m}{h}\big(g(t_m)+o(1)\big)\,\frac{2}{m}\Big(\frac{t_m g(t_m)}{\alpha} + o(1)\Big) = \frac{2}{\alpha hm}\big(t_m^2 g(t_m)^2 + o(1)\big).$$

As $m$ runs over these values, $\log m = \alpha\log(h/t_m)$ runs over an interval of length $2\alpha\log M$ with steps $\log(1+1/m) = (1+o(1))/m$. So the sum of $1/m$ is $O(\log M)$, the $o(1)$ terms contribute $o(1/h)$, and the rest is a Riemann sum in the variable $\log m$. With $dm/m = -\alpha\,dt/t$ it is $\frac{2}{\alpha h}\big(\int_{1/M}^M t^2 g(t)^2\,\frac{\alpha\,dt}{t} + o(1)\big)$. Hence

$$hC_N = 2\int_{1/M}^M tg(t)^2\,dt + O(M^{-\alpha} + M^{-1}) + o(1),$$

where the $O$ term is uniform in $h$. By Lemma A.4(iv) we may let $M \to \infty$, and we get $NC_N = 2hC_N \to 4\int_0^\infty tg(t)^2\,dt$.

*Step 3.* Let $G_1, G_2$ be independent copies of $G$ and $Y = G_1/(G_1+G_2)$. The map $(G_1,G_2) \mapsto (Y, G_1+G_2)$ has inverse $(y,r) \mapsto (yr,(1-y)r)$ with Jacobian $r$. So $Y$ has the density $f(y) = \int_0^\infty r\,g(yr)\,g((1-y)r)\,dr$ on $(0,1)$. With $r = 2t$ we get $f(\frac12) = \int_0^\infty r\,g(r/2)^2\,dr = 4\int_0^\infty tg(t)^2\,dt$. Hence $NC_N \to f(\frac12)$ by Step 2. The function $f$ is continuous on $[\frac14, \frac34]$. Indeed, for such $y$ both $yr$ and $(1-y)r$ are at least $r/4$, so by Lemma A.4(iv) the integrand is at most $r\min(\|g\|_\infty^2, Cr^{-2-2\alpha})$. This is integrable, and dominated convergence applies.

*Step 4.* It remains to show that $f(\frac12) = \ell_\alpha(\frac12)$. We show that $Y$ has the density $\ell_\alpha$. To do this we compute the moments $\mathbb{E}W^p$ of $W = G_1/G_2$ for small $|p|$, and we check that a certain explicit density $\rho_\alpha$ has the same moments. The law of $Y$ does not change if $G$ is multiplied by a constant, so we may take $\mathbb{E}e^{-sG} = e^{-s^\alpha}$. For $x > 0$ and $0 < p < 1$,

$$x^p = \frac{p}{\Gamma(1-p)}\int_0^\infty s^{-p-1}(1-e^{-sx})\,ds, \qquad x^{-p} = \frac{1}{\Gamma(p)}\int_0^\infty s^{p-1}e^{-sx}\,ds.$$

We put $x = G$, take expectations and substitute $w = s^\alpha$. The first formula gives $\mathbb{E}G^p$ for $0 < p < \alpha$ and the second gives $\mathbb{E}G^{-p}$ for $0 < p < 1$. Together, $\mathbb{E}G^p = \Gamma(1-p/\alpha)/\Gamma(1-p)$ for $|p| < \alpha$ (see also [18, Theorem 2.6.3]). Now $Y = W/(1+W)$ and $\mathbb{E}W^p = \mathbb{E}G^p\,\mathbb{E}G^{-p}$ by independence. With $\Gamma(1-z)\Gamma(1+z) = \pi z/\sin(\pi z)$, which is the reflection formula [19, 5.5.3] combined with $\Gamma(1+z) = z\Gamma(z)$, this is

$$\mathbb{E}W^p = \frac{\Gamma(1-\frac{p}{\alpha})\Gamma(1+\frac{p}{\alpha})}{\Gamma(1-p)\Gamma(1+p)} = \frac{\sin\pi p}{\alpha\sin(\pi p/\alpha)}, \qquad 0 < |p| < \alpha.$$

Let $\rho_\alpha(w) = \frac{\sin\pi\alpha}{\pi}\,\frac{w^{\alpha-1}}{w^{2\alpha}+2w^\alpha\cos\pi\alpha+1}$ for $w > 0$. We use the classical integral

$$\int_0^\infty \frac{x^\beta\,dx}{x^2+2x\cos\vartheta+1} = \frac{\pi\sin\beta\vartheta}{\sin\vartheta\,\sin\pi\beta}, \qquad 0 < |\beta| < 1,\ 0 < \vartheta < \pi,$$

whose value at $\beta = 0$ is the limit $\vartheta/\sin\vartheta$. For $-1 < \beta < 0$ it follows from the partial fractions $\frac{1}{x^2+2x\cos\vartheta+1} = \frac{1}{2i\sin\vartheta}\big(\frac{1}{x+e^{-i\vartheta}} - \frac{1}{x+e^{i\vartheta}}\big)$ and $\int_0^\infty x^\beta(x+e^{\pm i\vartheta})^{-1}dx = -\pi e^{\pm i\beta\vartheta}/\sin(\pi\beta)$. The substitution $x \mapsto 1/x$ shows that the left side is even in $\beta$, and so is the right side. So the formula holds for $0 < \beta < 1$ too. We use it with $x = w^\alpha$, $\beta = p/\alpha$ and $\vartheta = \pi\alpha$. Then $w^{\alpha-1}dw = dx/\alpha$, and we get

$$\int_0^\infty w^p\rho_\alpha(w)\,dw = \frac{\sin\pi\alpha}{\pi\alpha}\cdot\frac{\pi\sin\pi p}{\sin\pi\alpha\,\sin(\pi p/\alpha)} = \mathbb{E}W^p \qquad (0 < |p| < \alpha).$$

At $p = 0$ the value $\vartheta/\sin\vartheta$ of the classical integral gives $\int_0^\infty \rho_\alpha = 1$, so $\rho_\alpha$ is a probability density. So $\log W$ and the logarithm of a variable with density $\rho_\alpha$ have the same moment generating function near 0. A moment generating function that is finite near 0 determines the law, so $W$ has density $\rho_\alpha$. Then $Y = W/(1+W)$ has density $\rho_\alpha(\frac{y}{1-y})(1-y)^{-2}$, and multiplying the numerator and the denominator by $(1-y)^{2\alpha}$ shows that this is $\ell_\alpha(y)$. Both $f$ and $\ell_\alpha$ are densities of $Y$ that are continuous near $\frac12$, so

$$f(\tfrac12) = \ell_\alpha(\tfrac12) = \frac{2\sin\pi\alpha}{\pi(1+\cos\pi\alpha)} = \frac{2}{\pi}\tan\frac{\pi\alpha}{2}.$$

Dividing $E_N = \frac12 N^{-\alpha}$ by $C_N$ gives the formula for $R_N$. □

# B Proof of Proposition 3.7

We bound a gamma ratio, bracket $C_N$ and $c_N$, prove a local limit theorem at the center, and then expand the crossing. We use the setting of Section 3 with two states and a fair first step. So $0 < c < 2$, $X_1$ is a fair sign, and the switch indicators $\chi_k = \mathbf{1}\{X_k \neq X_{k-1}\}$, $k \geq 2$, are independent Bernoulli$(c/k)$ variables, independent of $X_1$. Put

$$\rho(a,b) = \prod_{k=a+1}^{b} \Big(1 - \frac{c}{k}\Big) = \frac{\Gamma(b+1-c)\,\Gamma(a+1)}{\Gamma(b+1)\,\Gamma(a+1-c)}, \qquad \lambda_{t,N} = \frac{c}{t}\,\rho(t,N)$$

for integers $1 \leq a \leq b$ and $2 \leq t \leq N$. So $\lambda_{t,N}$ is the probability of a switch at time $t$ and none in $(t,N]$, and $E_N = \frac{1}{2}\rho(1,N)$. Let $T_s^+$ be the time of the $s$-th step equal to $+1$. Let $B$ be a Beta$(c,c)$ variable, $d_c = 4^{1-c}/\mathrm{B}(c,c)$ its density at $\frac{1}{2}$, and $\Theta(c) = \log\big(2\Gamma(2-c)\,d_c\big)$. For even $N$ we write $h = N/2$ and $C_N = \mathbb{P}(A_N = h)$. Changing the sign of every step preserves the law of the walk and sends $A_N$ to $N - A_N$. We call this flip symmetry.

## B.1 A gamma ratio

Gautschi's inequality [19, 5.6.4] says that $x^{1-s} < \Gamma(x+1)/\Gamma(x+s) < (x+1)^{1-s}$ for $x > 0$ and $0 < s < 1$. We claim that for $0 < c < 2$ and real $y \geq 2$,

$$\frac{\Gamma(y+1-c)}{\Gamma(y+1)} = y^{-c}(1+\vartheta) \qquad \text{with} \qquad -\frac{1}{y} \leq \vartheta \leq \frac{2}{y}. \tag{9}$$

If $c = 1$ the left side is $1/y$ and $\vartheta = 0$. If $c < 1$ we take $x = y$ and $s = 1 - c$. Then the left side lies between $(y+1)^{-c}$ and $y^{-c}$, and $(1+1/y)^{-c} \geq 1 - c/y \geq 1 - 1/y$. If $c > 1$ we take $x = y$ and $s = 2 - c$ and use $\Gamma(y+1-c) = \Gamma(y+2-c)/(y+1-c)$. Then the left side lies between $(y+1)^{1-c}/(y+1-c)$ and $y^{1-c}/(y+1-c)$. Here $y/(y+1-c) = 1 + (c-1)/(y+1-c) \leq 1 + 1/(y-1) \leq 1 + 2/y$, and $(1+1/y)^{1-c}\,y/(y+1-c) \geq (1+1/y)^{-1} \geq 1 - 1/y$.

## B.2 Averaging at the center and a bracket

**Lemma B.1** (averaging at the center)**.** *Let $N \geq 2$ be even and $T = T_h^+$. Then*

$$C_N = 2\sum_{r=h}^{N-1} \mathbb{P}(T = r)\,\lambda_{r+1,N} \qquad \textit{and} \qquad \sum_{r=h}^{N-1} \mathbb{P}(T = r) = \frac{1}{2}. \tag{10}$$

*If $0 < c \leq 1$, then $c/N \leq C_N \leq \lambda_{h+1,N}$.*

*Proof.* On the event $\{A_N = h,\, X_N = -1\}$ the last step equal to $+1$ is the $h$-th one, at a time $T = r \leq N - 1$. It is followed by a switch at $r+1$ and no switch in $(r+1, N]$. Conversely, these conditions give $A_N = h$ and $X_N = -1$. The event $\{T = r\}$ depends only on $X_1, \chi_2, \ldots, \chi_r$. So $\mathbb{P}(A_N = h,\, X_N = -1) = \sum_{r=h}^{N-1} \mathbb{P}(T = r)\,\lambda_{r+1,N}$, and flip symmetry gives the same value for $X_N = +1$. Next, $T \leq N - 1$ exactly when $A_{N-1} \geq h$. This has probability $\frac{1}{2}$, because $N - 1$ is odd and $A_{N-1}$ is symmetric about $(N-1)/2$. Finally $\lambda_{t+1,N}/\lambda_{t,N} = t/(t+1-c)$, which is at most 1 for $c \leq 1$. So $\lambda_{N,N} = c/N \leq \lambda_{t,N} \leq \lambda_{h+1,N}$ for $h+1 \leq t \leq N$, and by (10) $C_N$ is a weighted average of these values. □

For an integer $M \geq 2$ put $\eta_M(c) = M\rho(1,M)/(2c)$. Since $\rho(1,M)$ decreases in $c$ and equals $1/M$ at $c = 1$, the function $\eta_M$ decreases strictly on $(0,1]$, from $\infty$ at 0 to $\eta_M(1) = \frac{1}{2}$. Let $c^{(M)} \in (0,1)$ be the root of $\eta_M = 1$.

**Proposition B.2** (bracket). *The numbers $c^{(M)}$ increase with $M$, and $1-c^{(M)} = \frac{\log 2}{\log M+1+\gamma} + O\big((\log M)^{-3}\big)$. For every even $N \geq 2$ we have $c^{(h+1)} \leq c_N \leq c^{(N)}$. So $(1-c_N)\log N \to \log 2$, and $c_N \geq c^{(3)} = (9-\sqrt{57})/2 > 0.725$ for $N \geq 4$.*

*Proof.* The equation $\eta_M(c) = 1$ says that $\frac{1}{2}\rho(1,M) = c/M$, namely that the end for $M$ steps equals $c/M$. We compare $E_N$ with the two bounds for $C_N$ in Lemma B.1, and each comparison is an inequality for some $\eta_M$.

*Monotonicity.* For $c < 1$ we have $\eta_{M+1}/\eta_M = (M+1-c)/M > 1$. So $\eta_{M+1}(c^{(M)}) > 1$, and since $\eta_{M+1}$ decreases, $c^{(M+1)} > c^{(M)}$.

*The bracket.* By Proposition 3.6(b), $C_N < E_N$ for $c < c_N$ and $C_N > E_N$ for $c > c_N$, and $c_N < 1$. So it is enough to compare $C_N$ with $E_N$ for $0 < c < 1$. Let $c^{(N)} < c < 1$. Then $\eta_N(c) < 1$, that is $E_N = \frac{1}{2}\rho(1,N) < c/N$, and $c/N \leq C_N$ by Lemma B.1. So $C_N > E_N$, which means $c > c_N$. Hence $c_N \leq c^{(N)}$. Now let $c < c^{(h+1)}$. Then $\eta_{h+1}(c) > 1$, that is $\frac{1}{2}\rho(1,h+1) > c/(h+1)$. With $\rho(1,N) = \rho(1,h+1)\rho(h+1,N)$ this gives $E_N > \frac{c}{h+1}\rho(h+1,N) = \lambda_{h+1,N} \geq C_N$. So $c < c_N$. Hence $c_N \geq c^{(h+1)}$.

*The expansion.* The number $c^{(3)}$ solves $3\rho(1,3) = (2-c)(3-c)/2 = 2c$, that is $c^2 - 9c + 6 = 0$. For $N \geq 4$ we have $h+1 \geq 3$, so $c_N \geq c^{(h+1)} \geq c^{(3)}$. By (9) with $y = M$ we have $M\rho(1,M) = M^{1-c}(1+O(1/M))/\Gamma(2-c)$. So the equation $\eta_M(c) = 1$ reads $(1-c)\log M = \Theta_0(c) + O(1/M)$ with $\Theta_0(c) = \log\big(2c\,\Gamma(2-c)\big)$, uniformly for $0 < c \leq 1$. For $M \geq 3$ we have $c^{(M)} \in [c^{(3)}, 1)$, where $\Theta_0$ is bounded. So $\varepsilon = 1 - c^{(M)}$ is $O(1/\log M)$, and we may expand at $c = 1$. We have $\Theta_0(1) = \log 2$ and $\Theta_0'(1) = 1 - \psi(1) = 1 + \gamma$, where $\psi = \Gamma'/\Gamma$ and $\psi(1) = -\gamma$ [19, 5.4.12]. Taylor's theorem gives $\varepsilon(\log M + 1 + \gamma) = \log 2 + O(\varepsilon^2) + O(1/M)$, which is the expansion. The limit of $(1-c_N)\log N$ follows since $\log(h+1) \sim \log N$. □

## B.3 A local limit at the center

**Proposition B.3** (local limit at the center). *For each compact $J \subset (0,2)$ there is $C_J$ such that $\big|NC_N - d_c\big| \leq C_J\sqrt{\log N/N}$ for $c \in J$ and even $N \geq 4$.*

*Proof.* We start from the averaging identity of Lemma B.1 and replace the law of $T = T_h^+$ by its continuum version. Since $T \leq r$ exactly when $A_r \geq h$, we need the law of $A_r$. The chain of Proposition 3.1 with $d = 2$ and $\theta = c$ switches with nearly the same probabilities as the walk, and its counts are binomial with a random parameter $B$. So $A_r$ is close in law to $rB$, and the time $T$ is close in law to $h/B$. The weights $\lambda_{r+1,N}$ are explicit, so the average becomes an explicit integral against the Beta$(c,c)$ density.

The proof has five steps. Step 1 shows that the counts of the chain are binomial with the random parameter $B$. Step 2 couples the walk with the chain and bounds the difference of the distribution functions of $T$ and $h/B$. Step 3 uses summation by parts to replace the law of $T$ by that of $h/B$ in the average. Step 4 writes the new sum as an expectation over $B$, and Step 5 evaluates it.

Let $F(r) = \mathbb{P}(T \leq r) = \mathbb{P}(A_r \geq h)$, $\Phi(r) = \mathbb{P}(rB \geq h)$ and $\Lambda_r = N\lambda_{r+1,N}$. By Lemma B.1,

$$NC_N = 2\sum_{r=h}^{N-1}\big(F(r) - F(r-1)\big)\Lambda_r.$$

In this proof $C$ depends only on $J$ and may change from line to line. Since $NC_N \leq N$ and $d_c$ is bounded on $J$, it is enough to prove the claim for large $N$. We put $K = \lceil\sqrt{N}\rceil$, $u = \sqrt{N\log N}$ and $w = K + u$, and we take $N$ so large that $w \leq h/4$. Note that $K \leq h$.

*Step 1 (a chain with binomial counts).* Let $X'$ be the chain of Proposition 3.1 with $d = 2$ and $\theta = c$, written with the states $\pm 1$, and let $A'_r$ be its number of steps $+1$ among the first $r$. Its first step is a fair sign, and at step $k \geq 2$ it switches with probability $q_k = c/(k-1+2c)$, independently of the past. By Proposition 3.1 and $x^{(m)} = \Gamma(x+m)/\Gamma(x)$,

$$\mathbb{P}(A'_r = s) = \binom{r}{s} \frac{c^{(s)} c^{(r-s)}}{(2c)^{(r)}} = \binom{r}{s} \frac{\mathrm{B}(c+s, c+r-s)}{\mathrm{B}(c,c)} = \mathbb{E}\Big[\binom{r}{s} B^s (1-B)^{r-s}\Big].$$

So $A'_r$ has the law of a binomial variable with $r$ trials and the random success probability $B$. By Hoeffding's inequality [30, Theorem 1], a binomial variable with $r$ trials and success probability $x$ is at least $rx + u$ with probability at most $e^{-2u^2/r}$, and the same holds for being at most $rx - u$. Hence for every real $y$

$$\mathbb{P}(rB \geq y + u) - e^{-2u^2/r} \leq \mathbb{P}(A'_r \geq y) \leq \mathbb{P}(rB \geq y - u) + e^{-2u^2/r}.$$

*Step 2 (coupling the walk with $X'$).* The switch probabilities differ by $c/k - q_k = c(2c-1)/(k(k-1+2c))$, which is at most $6/(k(k-1))$ in absolute value since $c < 2$. Let $K \leq r \leq N$. For $K < k \leq r$ we couple the switch indicator $\chi_k$ of the walk with the switch indicator $\chi'_k$ of $X'$ so that $\mathbb{P}(\chi_k \neq \chi'_k) = |c/k - q_k|$, using independent extra randomness. We put $X_K = X'_K$ and $X_k = X_{k-1}(-1)^{\chi_k}$ for $K < k \leq r$, and we draw $X_1, \dots, X_{K-1}$ from the law of the walk given $X_K$, again with independent randomness. In both processes the sign at step $K$ is fair, and the later switches are independent of the first $K$ steps. So $(X_1, \dots, X_r)$ has the law of the walk. Outside an event of probability at most $\sum_{k>K} 6/(k(k-1)) = 6/K$ the two processes agree at the steps $K, \dots, r$, and then $|A_r - A'_r| < K$. With Step 1, $w = K + u$ and $e^{-2u^2/r} \leq e^{-2\log N}$, this gives

$$|F(r) - \Phi(r)| \leq \mathbb{P}(h - w \leq rB < h + w) + \frac{1}{N^2} + \frac{6}{K} \qquad (K \leq r \leq N).$$

*Step 3 (replacing $F$ by $\Phi$).* Put $\Delta(r) = F(r) - \Phi(r)$. Then $\Delta(h-1) = 0$, because $A_{h-1} < h$ and $B < 1$. Summation by parts gives

$$\sum_{r=h}^{N-1} \big(\Delta(r) - \Delta(r-1)\big)\Lambda_r = \Delta(N-1)\Lambda_{N-1} - \sum_{r=h}^{N-2} \Delta(r)\big(\Lambda_{r+1} - \Lambda_r\big).$$

The ratio $\lambda_{t+1,N}/\lambda_{t,N} = t/(t+1-c)$ gives $\Lambda_{r+1} - \Lambda_r = \Lambda_r(c-1)/(r+2-c)$. Every factor of $\rho(r+1, N)$ lies in $(0,1)$, so $\Lambda_r = \frac{Nc}{r+1}\rho(r+1,N) \leq 2c$ for $r \geq h$. Hence $\Lambda_{N-1} = c$ and $|\Lambda_{r+1} - \Lambda_r| \leq 2c/h \leq 8/N$, and the right side is at most $c|\Delta(N-1)| + \frac{8}{N}\sum_{r=h}^{N-2}|\Delta(r)|$ in absolute value. For each value $b$ of $B$ the number $rb$ lies in $[h-w, h+w)$ for at most $2w/b + 1$ integers $r$, and for no $r \leq N$ unless $b \geq (h-w)/N \geq \frac{3}{8}$. So the probabilities in Step 2 add up to at most $6w + 1$ over $r$, and $\sum_{r=h}^{N-2}|\Delta(r)| \leq 6w + 2 + 6\sqrt{N}$. For $r = N-1$ the event in Step 2 puts $B$ in an interval of length $2w/(N-1)$ inside $[\frac{3}{8}, \frac{3}{4}]$, where the density of $B$ is at most $C$ for $c \in J$. So $|\Delta(N-1)| \leq Cw/N + N^{-2} + 6/K$. Together, replacing $F$ by $\Phi$ changes $NC_N$ by at most $C(w/N + 1/K) \leq C\sqrt{\log N/N}$.

*Step 4 (the new sum is an expectation).* After the replacement the sum is $2\sum_{r=h}^{N-1}(\Phi(r) - \Phi(r-1))\Lambda_r$. The term with $r = h$ vanishes, since $\Phi(h) = \Phi(h-1) = 0$. For $h < r \leq N-1$ we have $\Phi(r) - \Phi(r-1) = \mathbb{P}(h/r \leq B < h/(r-1))$, and on this event $\lceil h/B \rceil = r$. These events are disjoint, and their union is $\{h/(N-1) \leq B < 1\}$. So the new sum is $2\,\mathbb{E}\big[\Lambda_{\lceil h/B \rceil};\, B \geq h/(N-1)\big]$.

*Step 5 (evaluating the expectation).* By (9) with $y = N$ and $y = r+1 \geq 3$, $\Lambda_r = c\big((r+1)/N\big)^{c-1}(1 + O(1/N))$ for $h \leq r \leq N-1$. On the event above with $r = \lceil h/B \rceil$, the number $(r+1)/N$

lies in $[\frac12,2]$ and within $2/N$ of $h/(BN)=1/(2B)$, which also lies in $[\frac12,2]$. The function $x^{c-1}$ is 4-Lipschitz on $[\frac12,2]$. So $\Lambda_{\lceil h/B\rceil}=c(2B)^{1-c}+O(1/N)$. Also $\mathbb{P}\big(\frac12\le B<h/(N-1)\big)=O_J(1/N)$, since the density of $B$ is bounded near $\frac12$ uniformly on $J$. So we may replace the event $\{B\ge h/(N-1)\}$ by $\{B\ge\frac12\}$. In the remaining integral the factor $b^{1-c}$ cancels the factor $b^{c-1}$ of the density. Hence, by Step 3, $NC_N$ is within $C\sqrt{\log N/N}$ of

$$2c\,\mathbb{E}\big[(2B)^{1-c};\,B\ge\tfrac12\big]+O_J(1/N)=\frac{2c\,2^{1-c}}{\mathrm{B}(c,c)}\int_{1/2}^{1}(1-b)^{c-1}\,db+O_J(1/N)=d_c+O_J(1/N).\qquad\square$$

### B.4 The expansion of the crossing

*Proof of Proposition 3.7.* We write $\log C_N-\log E_N$ as an explicit function of $c$ with a small error, and we solve for its zero near $c=1$. Let $J=[c^{(3)},1]$. Then $d_c$ is bounded below on $J$ by a positive constant. By (9) with $y=N$, $\log E_N=\log\big(\frac12\rho(1,N)\big)=-\log 2-\log\Gamma(2-c)-c\log N+O(1/N)$. By Proposition B.3, $\log C_N=\log d_c-\log N+O(\sqrt{\log N/N})$ for large $N$. Both hold uniformly for $c\in J$, so

$$\log C_N-\log E_N=(c-1)\log N+\Theta(c)+O(\sqrt{\log N/N})\qquad(c\in J).\tag{11}$$

Here $\Theta(1)=\log 2$ because $d_1=1$. Next, $\Theta'(c)=-\psi(2-c)-\log 4-2\psi(c)+2\psi(2c)$, and with $\psi(1)=-\gamma$ and $\psi(2)=1-\gamma$ [19, 5.4.12, 5.4.14] this gives $\Theta'(1)=\gamma+2-2\log 2$. Put $L=\log N+\Theta'(1)$. By Proposition B.2, $c_N\in J$ for $N\ge4$ and $\varepsilon=1-c_N$ is $O(1/\log N)$. The left side of (11) vanishes at $c=c_N$, because $C_N=E_N$ there. As $\Theta$ is smooth on $J$, Taylor's theorem gives $\Theta(c_N)=\log 2-\varepsilon\,\Theta'(1)+O(\varepsilon^2)$. So (11) at $c=c_N$ reads $0=-\varepsilon\log N+\log 2-\varepsilon\,\Theta'(1)+O(\varepsilon^2)+O(\sqrt{\log N/N})$, that is $\varepsilon L=\log 2+O(\varepsilon^2)+O(\sqrt{\log N/N})=\log 2+O(L^{-2})$. So $\varepsilon=\log 2/L+O(L^{-3})$, which is the expansion. $\square$

With one more term in Taylor's theorem and $\varepsilon^2=(\log 2)^2/L^2+O(L^{-4})$, the same argument adds the term $-\Theta''(1)(\log 2)^2/(2L^3)$ to the expansion of $c_N$, with error $O(L^{-4})$. Here $\Theta''(1)=\pi^2/2-4$, since $\Theta''(c)=\psi'(2-c)-2\psi'(c)+4\psi'(2c)$, $\psi'(1)=\zeta(2)$ and $\psi'(2)=\zeta(2)-1$ [19, 5.4.12, 5.15.5]. At $N=200$ the bracket of Proposition B.2 is $[0.88749,0.89878]$, Proposition 3.7 gives 0.89319, and with the $L^{-3}$ term we get 0.89236. The high-precision value is $c_{200}=0.89253$. The constants $C_J$ and the constants in the $O$-terms of this appendix are not computed.

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**Funding.** No funding was received for this work.

**Data availability.** This paper uses no external data. The data computed for it (the cached data of Figure 1 and the prediction ledgers) are in the folder `kagey-problems/problem131/paperF` of `https://github.com/apemm/Kagey-Problems`. The code revision is identified below.

**Code availability.** All code and Lean files supporting this paper are in the folder `kagey-problems/problem131` of the same repository, at revision `c98db25`. To rerun the checks, run `python -B verify_all.py --paper f` in that folder, which takes a few minutes. With the option `--full` it also runs the heavy cells (among them the formula of Proposition 2.2 at $N=10^5$), and it then takes about twenty minutes. The scripts are in the subfolder `paperF` and need `numpy`, `scipy` and `mpmath`. Figure 1 is made by `paperD/figures/make_figures.py` and Figure 2 by

`paperF/figures/make_aging_figure.py`. The file `SUPPLEMENT.md` says what each script checks and where to find the predictions that we wrote down before each computation. Section 4 describes the checks.

## Declarations

**Competing interests.** The author has no competing interests to declare.

**Ethics approval and consent.** Not applicable.

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